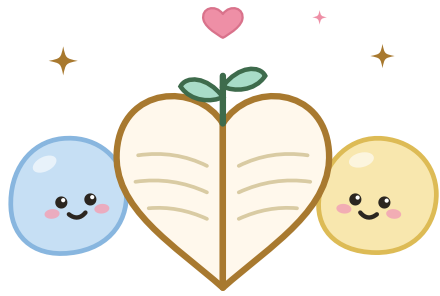
SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 4

Understanding People

How trust, change, loss, minds and groups work, for anyone



by Christian

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance, Book 4: *Understanding People*.
By Christian. Published by Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com.

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Free online, always. Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, in a short and a full version, with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com".

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. Every workpaper is free to print or fill in on the website: the book names it and gives a code to scan. *The Workpapers: Free Forms, All in One* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as “Tool: Chat analyzer”. You use it and it gives you something back.

The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, the cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, bounds in with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)

Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868
Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Part Three, Chapter 12 (online) says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 16, page **96** about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

1

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 1 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 5

Attachment, trust and belonging

Why we need each other, how the bonds we had early on shape what we expect today, and how trust and belonging are built, lost and rebuilt, one small moment at a time.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Belonging is a basic need
2. Early bonds teach us what to expect
3. Patterns, not boxes
4. Trust is built in small moments
5. Feeling safe with someone calms the body
6. Fitting in isn't the same as belonging
7. When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time
8. You can start building connection from wherever you are
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Belonging is a basic need.** Feeling lonely or left out is a signal, like hunger, not a flaw.
- **Early bonds set expectations, not a sentence.** What we learned about being cared for can soften and change.
- **Trust grows in small moments.** Doing what you said, again and again, matters more than big gestures.
- **You can start small.** One friendly exchange, one kept promise, one kind word to yourself.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **One owner per job** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) works because trust is built from small promises kept. A named owner turns a vague hope ("someone will do it") into a promise others can rely on. Big idea: *fix the setup, not the person.*
- **The monthly look-back** (Part Two, Chapter V (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5)) is "not a review of either person". Feeling safe with someone is what lets people say what went wrong without bracing for blame.

SUNDAY, 9:30PM

Kai sent a long message to a friend at lunchtime. It's been read, but there's no reply. By evening, Kai has gone from "she's busy" to "she's annoyed with me" to "nobody really likes me." The friend, meanwhile, is at her nephew's birthday, phone in a coat pocket. One silence, two very different nights.

01

Belonging is a basic need.

People need to feel connected, the way we need food and sleep. When we feel left out, it can hurt in a way that feels almost physical (Naomi Eisenberger and colleagues, 2003). That isn't weakness. It's a signal, like hunger, telling us to reach for connection.

For example: Rhea moves to a new city for work. She's busy and doing well, but by the third month she feels flat and teary on Sundays. Nothing is wrong with her. She's lonely, and loneliness is a real need asking to be met.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Feeling lonely doesn't mean I'm unlikeable. It means I need connection, like anyone."

TRY THIS:

This week, reach out to one person, even with a short "thinking of you" message.

02

Early bonds teach us what to expect.

As children, we learn from the people who cared for us whether others will come when we need them. If help usually came, we tend to expect it. If it came sometimes, or rarely, we may learn to cling harder or to stop asking. These lessons are a starting point, not a life sentence. This is the idea of attachment, first described by John Bowlby (1969) and studied by Mary Ainsworth and colleagues (1978).

For example: A toddler at the park runs off to explore, then runs back to check his grandmother is still on the bench, then runs off again. She is his safe base. Knowing she's there makes him brave enough to explore.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

(to a child) "I'm right here. Go and look, and come back whenever you want."

TRY THIS:

Think of one person who was a safe base for you, at any age. What did they do that helped?

03

Patterns, not boxes.

As adults, some of us worry a lot about being left, and reach out more when we feel unsure. Some of us pull back when things get close, and need more space. Many of us feel mostly secure, and most of us mix all three.

These are patterns that can soften and change, especially in steady, kind relationships. Cindy Hazan and Phillip Shaver (1987) first described them in adults, and later work, such as R. Chris Fraley and colleagues (2015), suggests they are sliding scales, not boxes.

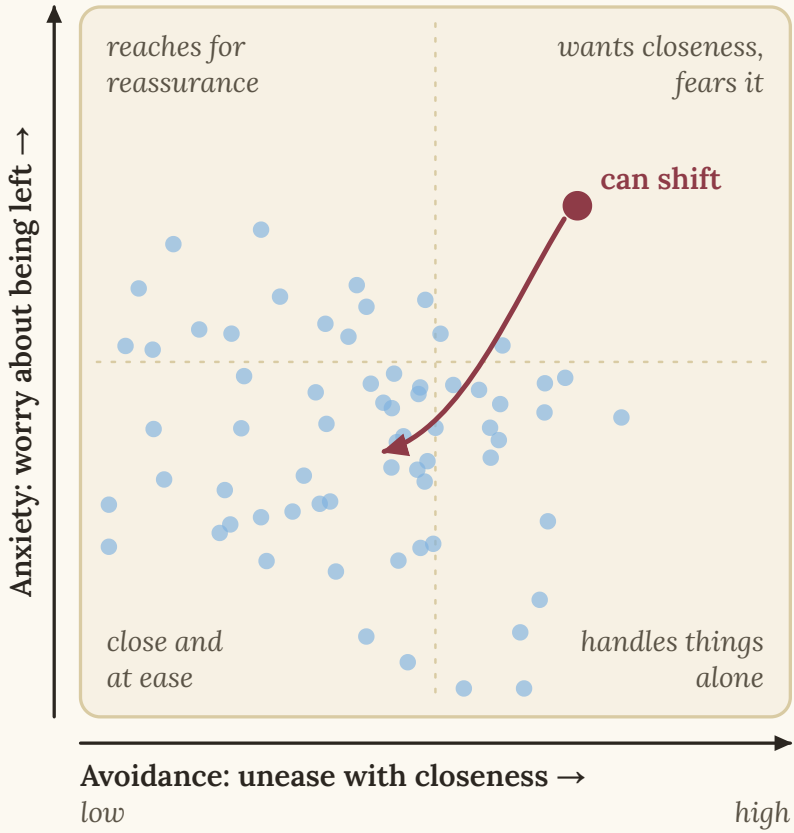
For example: When things feel tense, Ronan wants to talk it through right now. His wife Clara needs to go quiet first. He reads her quiet as "she's leaving." She reads his questions as pressure. Once they see the pattern, they agree: Clara says "I need an hour, and I'm coming back," and Ronan waits.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm not going anywhere. I just need some quiet. Let's talk at eight."

TRY THIS:
Notice what you do when you feel unsure of someone: reach out more, or pull back? No judgement, just notice.

Patterns, not boxes

Two scales. Everyone sits somewhere, and can move.



After Brennan, Clark and Shaver (1998) and Fraley and colleagues (2015): adult attachment is best measured as two scales, not types. Dots are illustrative, not data.

FIGURE 1 Attachment as two scales, not four boxes: worry about being left, and unease with closeness. Everyone sits somewhere, and can move. Dots are illustrative.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

Our pause plan
Imani and Kwame, married ten years

Our pause plan

Fill this in together on a calm day, or fill it in yourself and send it to your partner to change.

Our pause word or sentence
"Pause. I'll be back at …", with a hand on the heart

Shortest break, so our bodies can settle
30 minutes

Whoever pauses names a clock time to come back, no later than
the same evening

If one of us can't come back on time
Send one text with a new time. No silence.

The first sentence when we come back
"I'm back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?"

YOUR PLAN, READY TO SEND

Our pause plan

Pause word: “Pause. I’ll be back at …”, with a hand on the heart

Shortest break: 30 minutes

Return time: whoever pauses names a clock time, no later than the same evening

If one of us can’t come back on time: Send one text with a new time. No silence.

When we come back, we start with: “I’m back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?”

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. For relationships where everyone feels safe.

Fill in your own: Our pause plan (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw)

04

Trust is built in small moments.

Trust doesn’t usually come from big gestures. It grows from small, ordinary things done again and again: doing what you said, turning towards someone when they reach out, being the same person on a hard day as on a good one.

For example: A new team member says she’ll send the figures by Thursday, and she does. The next week, she flags early that something will be late. By the third month, her manager trusts her completely, not because of one big moment, but dozens of small ones.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

“I said I’d do it by Friday. I’m running late, so here’s where it’s at.”

TRY THIS:

Keep one small promise today, and notice how it feels to be someone who does what they said.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Trust grows in small moments that repeat. This workpaper helps you notice the little rituals you already have, and keep them going.



WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · free to print

· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15

05

Feeling safe with someone calms the body.

Being with someone we trust can settle our nervous system. In one study, holding a trusted partner's hand calmed the brain's response to threat (James Coan and colleagues, 2006). A calm voice, a hand to hold, or just someone nearby can make a hard moment easier to bear. This works both ways: we can be that safe presence for others too, often without saying much.

For example: After a panic attack, Kieran's friend doesn't try to fix anything. He sits next to him on the step and says, "Take your time. I'm here." Kieran's breathing slows.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"You don't have to talk. I'll just sit with you." "What would help right now: company, quiet, or both?"

TRY THIS:

Notice who helps you feel calmer. Tell them, simply: "I always feel better after seeing you."

06

Fitting in isn't the same as belonging.

Fitting in means changing yourself to be accepted. Belonging means being accepted as you are. Groups like teams, families, clubs and communities can offer both. Being left out of a group hurts, even when the group doesn't matter much to us. Real belonging grows where people feel safe to be themselves and to speak up.

For example: At a new job, Ola laughs at jokes she doesn't find funny and hides that she doesn't drink. She's fitting in, and she's exhausted. At a book club, she says what she really thinks and people ask her to say more. That's belonging.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> (in a group) "I see it a bit differently. Is it okay if I say why?" "Has everyone had a chance to say something?"

TRY THIS:
Think of one place where you can be fully yourself. How could you spend a little more time there?

07

When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time.

When someone lets us down badly, trust doesn't come back with one apology. It returns slowly, as words are matched by actions over time. The person who broke trust can own what happened and be patient. The person who was hurt can decide, at their own pace, whether and how much to trust again.

For example: Two adult sisters fall out after one shares a private story at a family dinner. The apology is a start. What rebuilds trust is the months afterwards, when the story never comes up again and the sister checks before sharing anything.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I know sorry isn't enough. I'll show you, and you can take whatever time you need."

TRY THIS:

If you've broken someone's trust, name one specific thing you'll do differently, and do it.

08

You can start building connection from wherever you are.

If you feel alone right now, big friendships can feel out of reach. But belonging starts small: a chat with a neighbour, a regular class, an online group about something you love, a kind word to yourself. Even small, light contact with people we barely know can lift our mood (Gillian Sandstrom and Elizabeth Dunn, 2014).

For example: After his divorce, Martin starts saying more than "thanks" to the man at the coffee stall. A few weeks later they talk football every morning. It isn't a deep friendship, but it makes Mondays easier, and it reminds him he can still connect.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm new around here. Is there anything you'd recommend?" "I loved what you said in the group. Would you like to get a coffee sometime?"

TRY THIS:

Have one small, friendly exchange with someone you don't know well this week.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: one small hello is a great start! Want an idea? There's a tool that picks one for you.

TOOL **Get one small bonding idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

MONDAY, 8:10AM

Kai's phone buzzes. "Sorry! Phone was in my coat all day at my nephew's party. Loved your message. Coffee Thursday?" Kai notices how far last night's story had run: from "she's busy" all the way to "nobody likes me." Next time a reply is slow, Kai decides to send a light "No rush, just thinking of you," and let the silence be just a silence.

If you're a teenager

A *made-up example.* Ezra, 16, sees a photo of his three closest friends at the cinema, and finds out there's a group chat he isn't in. It hurts like a punch. Being left out really does register a bit like pain. Instead of posting something sharp, he messages one friend: "Bit gutted not to be asked. Did I do something?" It turns out they thought he'd be at football. One friendship really is drifting, though, and that's allowed to hurt too.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Bit gutted not to be asked. Did something happen?" "I'd like to come next time, even if I can't always make it." "I miss how we used to be. Are we okay?"

In everyday life

- **Partners:** One partner texts a lot when apart; the other forgets. Agreeing on one goodnight message keeps both feeling connected.
- **Parents and children:** A child who acts up at pick-up may simply be releasing a long day with the safest person they know.
- **Friends:** A friend who always cancels may be overwhelmed, not uncaring. Asking "Is it easier if we do something short?" keeps the door open.
- **Coworkers:** A team where mistakes can be admitted without blame builds trust faster than one where everyone hides them.
- **Housemates:** A weekly shared meal, even a simple one, can turn people who share a kitchen into people who look out for each other.
- **Community:** A neighbour who waves every morning is a small, real part of feeling at home.

On your own: belonging with yourself

Belonging isn't only about other people. It also includes how you treat yourself. If you're kind to yourself on a bad day, you carry a little safe base wherever you go. People who learn to comfort themselves often find it easier to let others in, too, because they're less afraid of being let down.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "I'm allowed to need people." "Today was lonely. That's hard, and it won't always be like this."

More for people on their own: On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

Common mix-ups

- **"Needing people means I'm needy."** Needing connection is human. Everyone has this need, even those who hide it well.
- **"My attachment style is fixed for life."** Patterns can change, especially through steady, kind relationships and reflection.
- **"An 'anxious' or 'avoidant' label explains everything."** Labels can help you notice patterns, but people are more than a type. Use them for curiosity, not judgement.
- **"Jealousy and checking up show how much they love me."** Reaching for reassurance is human, and so is asking for something out of care for the relationship. Controlling who someone sees, or checking their phone without agreement, is not love and is not an attachment style. See signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety).
- **"If I forgive, I have to trust again straight away."** Forgiving and trusting are different. Trust can return slowly, or not at all, and that's your call.
- **"Belonging means everyone likes me."** Belonging usually means a few people who know you as you are. That's enough.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Be a steady presence.** Reliability matters more than big gestures. Turn up when you said you would.
- **Take loneliness seriously.** If someone says they feel alone, don't rush to "But you have so many friends!" Listen first.
- **Invite, and keep inviting.** People who feel left out may say no a few times. A warm, no-pressure invitation still matters.
- **Make room in groups.** Notice who is on the edge, and ask their view.

- **Don't diagnose.** Avoid telling someone they're "so avoidant" or "so clingy." Ask what would help instead.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm here, and I'm not going anywhere." "We're having a few people over on Friday. No pressure, but I'd love you to come."

When to get more help

- **If loneliness has lasted a long time,** or comes with low mood, hopelessness or thoughts of not wanting to be here, please talk to a doctor or a mental health service. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number or see Upset right now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now).
- **If fear of being left, or of getting close, keeps hurting your relationships,** a counsellor or therapist can help you understand where it comes from and how to change it.
- **If someone uses your need for them against you,** by cutting you off from friends, checking where you are, or threatening to leave to get their way, that is not about attachment. Not safe at home? lists free, private help.
- **If trust was broken in a way that frightened you,** you don't owe anyone a second chance. Your safety comes first.

Reading on the website

> PRACTICE:
> pick one small way to turn towards someone this week.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Bonding: how closeness grows (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding): what research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family, coworkers and you.
- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends): when a friendship drifts, and how to reach out.
- The languages of connection (spreadloveandacceptance.com/languages-of-connection): the different ways people show care.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good things fade, and how to keep them alive.

More for your situation

- On my own after a breakup
- Friends
- Parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) and foster, adoptive and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Belonging is a basic need.** Feeling lonely or left out is a signal, like hunger, not a flaw.
- ✓ **Early bonds set expectations, not a sentence.** What we learned about being cared for can soften and change.
- ✓ **Trust grows in small moments.** Doing what you said, again and again, matters more than big gestures.
- ✓ **You can start small.** One friendly exchange, one kept promise, one kind word to yourself.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1 · Where your lens came from
Early trust and the rules from home — Know Yourself Kindly

Book 2 · Closeness and love
Being known, at every age — Closer, Together

Chapter 6 · Groups, influence and culture
Belonging to groups, and their pull — page 101

Chapter 3 · Loss, grief and big life changes
When a bond is lost — page 39

PUT IT TO USE

Bonding: how closeness grows
What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family, coworkers and you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

Friends
When a friendship drifts, and how to reach out
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-5-belonging-in-depth

2

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 2 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 6

Habits and change: why change is hard and how small steps work

Why it's so hard to change, even when we really want to, and what actually helps: small steps, a kinder setup, patience with slips, and remembering that other people's change belongs to them.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Change is hard for good reasons
2. Habits run on cues
3. Start smaller than feels useful
4. Change the setup, not just your willpower
5. Being in two minds is normal
6. Slips are part of change
7. Change sticks when it fits who you want to be
8. You can support change, but not force it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Change is hard for good reasons.** Habits save effort, so the old way is always the easy way.
- **Small and set up beats big and willpower.** Make the first step tiny and change the setup around you.
- **Slips are part of change.** A missed day is information about the plan, not proof about you.
- **Other people's change is theirs.** You can support it. You can't force it.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **One small step a week** (the six-week program; Part One, Next (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next)) works because change that lasts starts smaller than feels useful, and an if-then plan does the deciding ahead of time.
- **The setup score and One owner per job** (Part Two, Chapter II (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2); Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) change the setup instead of asking for more willpower. Habits follow cues and easy paths. Big ideas: *fix the setup, not the person* and *notice the quiet incentives.*
- **What keeps coming back?** (Part Two, Chapter V (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5)) treats a repeat as information, not failure, because slips are a normal part of change.

MONDAY, 7:05AM

The plan was a walk before work. The trainers are by the door. But the phone is in your hand, and somehow it's 7:40 and you're scrolling with cold coffee. By evening, a quiet voice says: "See? You never stick to anything." That voice is wrong. You aren't weak. You've met a habit.

01

Change is hard for good reasons.

Much of what we do each day runs on autopilot. That saves energy, which is why habits exist. The downside is that the old way is always quicker and easier than the new one. Change asks your brain to do something effortful, again and again, until the new way becomes the easy one.

For example: Jodie wants to stop snapping at her kids in the morning rush. She means it every night. Every morning, the same rush brings the same snap. She isn't a bad parent; the morning is a well-worn groove.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"This is hard because it's a habit, not because I'm failing." "Old grooves take time to fill in."

TRY THIS:

Pick one thing you'd like to change and write: "When does it usually happen? Where? What's going on just before?"

02

Habits run on cues.

Most habits have a trigger: a time, a place, a feeling, a person, or the thing you just did. The cue starts the routine, and some kind of reward (relief, comfort, a little buzz) keeps it going. If you know the cue, you can plan for it.

For example: A man notices he reaches for snacks not when he's hungry but when he opens his laptop after dinner. The cue is the laptop. He starts making tea first instead.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

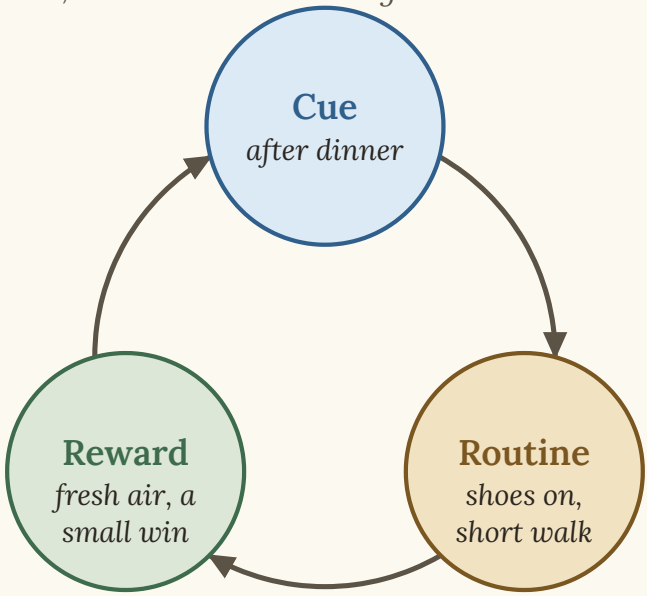
"What happened right before I did that?" "What was I getting from it?"

TRY THIS:

For three days, each time the habit happens, jot down the cue: time, place, feeling, or what you were doing.

Habits run on cues

Over time, the cue alone is enough.



Change the setup, not just your willpower: *move the cue, make the step tiny.*

The cue, routine and reward loop is a popular simplification; the core idea, that context triggers habits, is well supported (for example Neal, Wood and colleagues, 2011).

FIGURE 2 Habits run on cues. Over time the cue alone is enough, so change the setup, not just your willpower.

03

Start smaller than feels useful.

Big goals are inspiring but easy to drop. Tiny steps feel almost silly, and that's why they work: they're easy enough to do on a bad day. Tie the new step to something you already do: "After I put the kettle on, I'll..." Once it sticks, you can grow it.

For example: Two housemates want a tidier kitchen. Instead of a big weekly clean they never do, they agree: "After dinner, we each wipe one surface." It takes two minutes, and the kitchen stays nicer.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Let's start with something tiny, and see if it sticks." "After I ..., I will ..."

TRY THIS:

Shrink your change until it takes two minutes or less. Write it as "After I ___, I will ___."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

Your done list

Bernie, 71, living on his own

Your done list

Write down one small thing that went right, however small.

A small win

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe

Who it was with

With a friend

THIS WEEK: 4 SMALL WINS

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe · Thu, Oct 8 · With a friend

Cleared one shelf in the spare room · Wed, Oct 7

Rang my brother back · Tue, Oct 6 · With family

Walked to the post office instead of driving · Mon, Oct 5

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. A done list is for encouragement, not proving who does more.

Fill in your own: Your done list (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

04

Change the setup, not just your willpower.

Willpower runs low when we're tired, hungry or stressed. Your surroundings don't. Make the new habit easier (put it in sight, get things ready the night before) and the old one a little harder (move it out of reach, add a step). Small changes to your setup can do more than any amount of trying harder.

For example: A teenager wants to sleep better. Instead of "trying not to scroll," he charges his phone in the kitchen. It works far better than willpower ever did.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

(to yourself or a partner) "What could we change about the setup so this gets easier?"

TRY THIS:

Make one small change to your space today that makes the new habit easier or the old one harder.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Changing the setup is often easier than changing a person. At home, that can be as simple as one owner for each job.



WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

05

Being in two minds is normal.

Part of you wants to change. Part of you doesn't, and that part usually has its reasons: the old habit gives comfort, saves effort, or protects you from something. Pushing harder against that part rarely works. Listening to it often does.

For example: Asif wants to drink less, but he also loves the Friday pub with his team. Instead of "never again," he asks what Friday gives him: friends, laughing, unwinding. He keeps the Friday, and switches to alcohol-free after the first drink.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"What does the old habit give me?" "What would make the change worth it to me, not just to others?"

TRY THIS:

Write two lists: "What I like about how things are" and "What I'd like about changing." Both lists are allowed.

06

Slips are part of change.

Nearly everyone who changes something slips back sometimes. One slip doesn't undo your progress. What often does is the thought that follows: "I've blown it, so why bother?" Treating yourself kindly after a slip makes it more likely you'll start again, not less.

For example: After three calm weeks, a dad shouts at his son over homework. That night he says, "I shouted, and I'm sorry. I'm working on it." The next day he's back on track. The slip became a repair, not a reason to give up.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"A slip is a moment, not a verdict." "What made today harder, and what can I plan for next time?"

TRY THIS:

Decide now what you'll do after a slip: one kind sentence to yourself, and one small step to start again.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: a slip is a stumble, not a fall. Shake it off and try the tiny step again tomorrow. A game for small kind acts makes practising more fun!

TOOL **Calm football game for small kind acts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

07

Change sticks when it fits who you want to be.

Change done only to please others, or out of shame, is hard to keep. Change that connects to what you care about, the kind of person, parent, friend or colleague you want to be, has deeper roots. Each small action is a vote for that person.

For example: A woman who wants to "be better at keeping in touch" reframes it: "I'm someone who shows up for my friends." Sending one voice note a week becomes part of who she is, not a chore.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Who am I becoming with this step?" "This matters to me because..."

TRY THIS:

Finish this sentence for your change: "I want to do this because I care about..."

08

You can support change, but not force it.

It's natural to want people we love to change: to drink less, tidy more, look after themselves. But other people's change belongs to them. Pressure tends to make people dig in. What helps more: saying clearly what you need, asking what would help, and noticing their small steps out loud.

For example: A coworker keeps missing deadlines. Instead of "You need to be more organised," his teammate asks, "What would make the handover easier for you?" They set up a shared checklist, and the deadlines improve.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I can't change this for you, but I'd love to help if you want me to." "I noticed you did that this week. That really helped."

TRY THIS:

Notice one small positive change someone else made this week, and tell them.

TWO WEEKS LATER, 7:05AM

The trainers are still by the door, but the phone now charges in the kitchen overnight. The plan has shrunk too: shoes on and out to the end of the road. Some mornings that's all. Most mornings it turns into a walk. On the day you miss, the voice says "See?" and you answer it: "A missed day is a slip, not a verdict. Tomorrow, the end of the road."

In everyday life

- **Partners:** One partner wants to spend less time on phones in the evening. They agree on a basket for both phones after nine, not a rule for one person.
- **Parents and children:** A picture chart of the bedtime steps makes a new routine easier for a young child than reminders ever did.
- **Friends:** Two friends who want to move more meet for a Saturday walk. The friendship is the reward that keeps the habit going.
- **Coworkers:** A team that keeps forgetting actions starts ending every meeting with "Who does what by when?" It's a tiny habit with a big effect.
- **Housemates:** A shared list on the fridge works better than anyone trying to remember.
- **Big life changes:** A move, a new baby or a new job breaks old routines. That's disruptive, and it's also a good moment to start new habits.
- **If you have ADHD:** Make the cue impossible to miss, do the step the moment it appears, and make the reward come now. Expect novelty to wear off and swap the method, rather than blaming yourself. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-6-change-in-depth).

On your own: a kind plan for change

If you're working on something alone, put the ideas together in one small plan:

- **One change.** Not five. Pick the one that would make the most difference, or the one that feels most doable.
- **One cue.** "After I ___, I will ___."

- **One setup tweak.** Make it easier to start.
- **One tired-day version.** The smallest version you can still do on a bad day.
- **One kind sentence for slips.** Written down, ready to use.

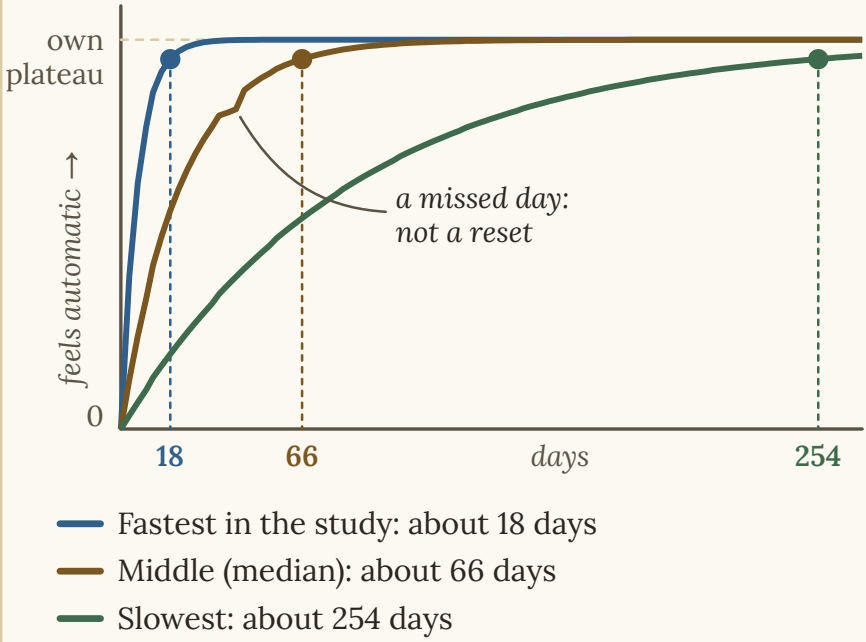
The individual program walks through this step by step: The self path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) and Know yourself, next.

Common mix-ups

- **"If I really wanted it, I'd just do it."** Wanting is only the start. Habits, setup, tiredness and stress all matter.
- **"It takes 21 days to form a habit."** There's no magic number. In one study, led by Phillippa Lally (2010), it took about two months on average, with a very wide range.
- **"One slip means I've failed."** Slips are normal. Starting again is the skill.
- **"Being hard on myself will keep me on track."** Harshness tends to make people give up. Kindness makes it easier to try again.
- **"If I nag enough, they'll change."** Pressure often makes people dig in. Ask, support and notice instead.
- **"Routines mean being rigid."** For many people, especially autistic people, routines are what make life manageable. Change can respect that.

About two months, give or take a lot

How automatic a new daily habit feels, over time.



- Fastest in the study: about 18 days
- Middle (median): about 66 days
- Slowest: about 254 days

Illustrative shapes, not the raw data. Lally and colleagues (2010) followed 96 volunteers; reaching 95% of each person's own plateau took 18 to 254 days, median 66. Simpler habits formed faster.

FIGURE 3 How long a new habit takes to feel automatic: about two months on average, with a very wide range. Illustrative shapes based on Lally and colleagues (2010).

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Ask before advising.** "Would ideas help, or would you rather just talk it through?"

- **Help them find their own reasons.** "What would be different for you if this changed?"
- **Help with the setup.** Offer practical things: a lift to the gym, a shared calendar, a quieter evening.
- **Notice small steps out loud.** Encouragement for small wins often helps more than pointing out what's still missing.
- **Be kind about slips.** "That's okay, tomorrow's a new go" helps more than "I knew it."
- **Look after yourself.** You can care deeply and still set limits on what you'll put up with.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm on your side with this. What would help?" "You've done this three days running. That's not nothing."

When to get more help

- **If a habit is harming your health or life,** such as drinking, drugs, gambling, eating or self-harm, please talk to a doctor or a specialist service. Needing help with this is common and nothing to be ashamed of.
- **If you can't stop even though you've tried many times,** professional support can make a real difference. It isn't a sign of weakness.
- **If change feels impossible because you're exhausted or low most days,** that may be burnout or depression. A doctor or counsellor can help.
- **If someone is demanding you change in ways that frighten you,** or punishing you when you don't, that isn't support. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.
- **If you're overwhelmed right now,** start with Upset right now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now).

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

PRACTICE:
pick one tiny change and try it for a week.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Know yourself, next: values, one small goal, tiny steps and if-then plans.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive.

More for your situation

- On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- New parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Gaming, phones and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Change is hard for good reasons.** Habits save effort, so the old way is always the easy way.
- ✓ **Small and set up beats big and willpower.** Make the first step tiny and change the setup around you.
- ✓ **Slips are part of change.** A missed day is information about the plan, not proof about you.
- ✓ **Other people's change is theirs.** You can support it. You can't force it.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1 · Who you are becoming — Know Yourself Kindly
One small goal and tiny steps

Book 3 · The monthly look-back — Share the Load
The monthly look-back

Book 3 · Is the split working? — Share the Load
Changing the setup, not the person

Book 1 · Personality, temperament and change — Know Yourself Kindly
How much people really change

PUT IT TO USE



Know yourself, next
Values, one small goal, tiny steps and if-then plans
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next`



Complacency
Why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency`



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-6-change-in-depth`

3

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 3 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 8

Loss, grief and big life changes

What grief is, why it comes in waves, how it shows up in the body, and how to carry a loss, or a big change, without having to "get over it."

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Grief is love with nowhere to go
2. Grief comes in waves, not neat stages
3. Grief lives in the body, too
4. Some losses nobody sees
5. People grieve in different ways
6. You don't have to let go
7. Big changes are losses too, even the good ones
8. Most people find a way through, and support helps
9. Losing a partner in later life
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Grief is love with nowhere to go.** It hurts because the person, place or life mattered.
- **It comes in waves, not stages.** A good week and then a bad day is normal, not going backwards.
- **You don't have to let go.** Many people keep a bond with the person they lost, and that's healthy.
- **Most people find a way through.** Support helps, and some losses need more help. Both are normal.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **Who did what and the setup score** (the Preface to Part Two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface); Part Two, Chapter II (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2)) help after a death, an illness, a move or a new baby, because a big change quietly moves jobs from one person to another. Looking at the month again lets you share the new load on purpose. Big idea: *see the whole load.*
- **"A full tank means later, not never"** (Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3)) fits grief: grief fills the tank, so some talks wait for a better day, with a time named.
- **Where your lens came from** (Part One, Then (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then)) looks at older losses that still shape how you react today.

SATURDAY, 9:05AM

Six months on, you're doing fine. Then, in the supermarket, you see the cereal your dad always bought, and you have to leave your trolley in the aisle and sit in the car. Nobody around you knows. It feels like day one again.

This chapter is for anyone who has lost someone or something: a person, a pet, a marriage, a friendship, health, a home, a job, a country or a future you had pictured. It explains how grief works first, then what can help. There is no right way to grieve, and nothing here is a timetable.

01

Grief is love with nowhere to go.

Grief is what we feel when something we were attached to is gone. It isn't only for deaths. A divorce, a miscarriage, a diagnosis, a move, a friend who drifted, or children leaving home can all bring real grief. The size of the grief usually matches the size of the bond, not what other people think the loss "should" mean.

For example: A man is surprised how hard he takes his dog's death. His friends say "it was just a dog." But that dog walked with him every morning for twelve years.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"This hurts because it mattered." "My grief doesn't need anyone's permission."

TRY THIS:

Name one loss you've been carrying that you haven't called grief. Say it to yourself: "I'm grieving…"

02

Grief comes in waves, not neat stages.

You may have heard of five stages: denial, anger, bargaining, depression, acceptance. They came from listening to dying patients, and were never meant as steps everyone follows in order. Most people swing back and forth: some hours deep in the loss, some hours getting on with life. That back-and-forth is healthy. Laughing at a funeral, or having a good day, doesn't mean you've stopped caring.

For example: A widow feels guilty that she enjoyed lunch with her sister. Then she cries all evening. Both were grief doing its work.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

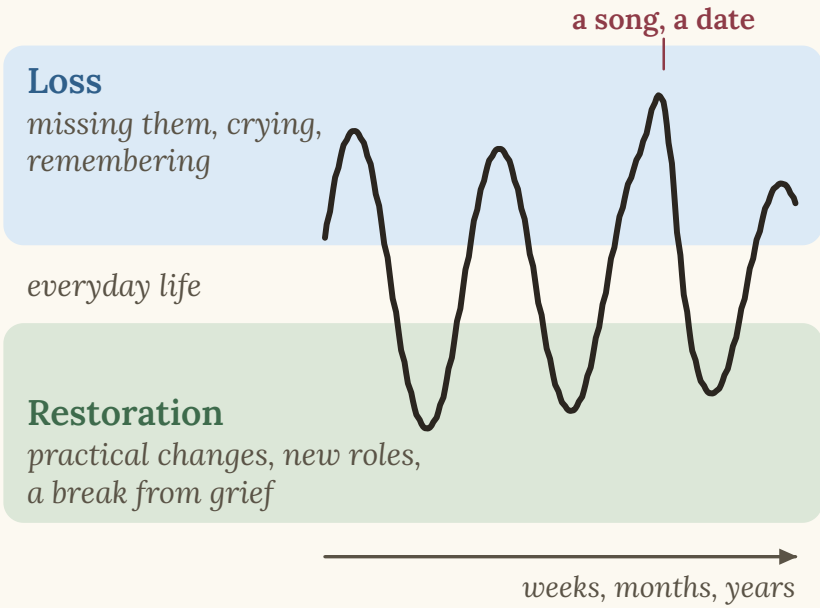
"A good hour isn't a betrayal." "This is a wave. Waves pass."

TRY THIS:

Let yourself have one small break from grief today, without guilt: a walk, a show, a meal with a friend.

Grief comes in waves

Moving back and forth between loss and life is part of it.



Waves, not neat stages. A good week, then a bad day, is normal, not going backwards.

After Stroebe and Schut's dual process model (1999), a widely used framework rather than a precise prediction. Illustrative line.

FIGURE 4 Grief comes in waves, not neat stages. Moving back and forth between loss and everyday life is part of healthy grieving.

03

Grief lives in the body, too.

Grief can bring tiredness, poor sleep, no appetite or extra appetite, aches, a tight chest, forgetfulness and a foggy head. Your brain is slowly learning that someone or something it expected to be there isn't. That takes time, and it uses energy.

For example: A teacher whose mother died keeps losing her keys and forgetting meetings. She worries something is wrong with her memory. It's grief fog, and it eases as the months pass.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm grieving, so I'm slower than usual. Could you send me a reminder?"

TRY THIS:

Pick three basics to protect this week: one regular meal, a set bedtime, and a short walk outside.

04

Some losses nobody sees.

Some losses are hard to explain. Someone is still alive but changed, through dementia, addiction or illness. Someone is gone but not dead, like an estranged parent or a missing relative. Some losses aren't recognised by others: an ex-partner's death, a pregnancy loss, a friend you met online. Grief without a ceremony, or without other people noticing, can feel very lonely.

For example: A woman's father has dementia. He's still here, and she still visits, but the dad who knew her is fading. She's grieving someone who hasn't died.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm grieving something people might not see as a loss. It is one for me."

TRY THIS:

If a loss of yours had no ceremony, make a small one: light a candle, write a letter, plant something, visit a place.

05

People grieve in different ways.

Some people grieve by talking and crying. Others grieve by doing: fixing, organising, working, building something. Neither is more loving. Families often clash because one person thinks the other "isn't grieving" when they are just grieving differently. Culture, faith, age and how your mind works all shape it, too.

For example: After their son's death, one parent wants to talk about him every evening. The other spends weekends restoring his old bike. Each feels the other is getting it wrong. Both are grieving him.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think we grieve differently. Can you tell me what helps you, and I'll tell you what helps me?"

TRY THIS:

Ask someone who shares your loss: "What has helped you most, even a little?" Listen without correcting.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

Talk it through in writing

Edith, 74, seven months after her husband died, writing to her son and daughter

Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)
Malcolm and Fiona

Your name (optional)
Mum

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · *Make a plan* · Say sorry · I need a pause

What we need to plan (one thing)
How often we ring and visit. Since your dad died in March, I've had a call every evening at seven and a visit every Sunday.

How I feel about it

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · hurt · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · embarrassed · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · *grateful*

What I suggest (one clear suggestion)
Could we change to a call on Wednesdays and Sundays, and I'll ring you if I need you in between?

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)
I'm not pushing you away. I love hearing from you, and I miss your dad too.

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Fiona rang the same evening: "Of course. Will you still tell us on a bad day?" Edith said she would.

Fill in your own: Talk it through in writing
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through)

06

You don't have to let go.

An older idea said healthy grief meant "moving on" and cutting ties. Many grief researchers now see it differently: people often keep a bond with who they lost, in memories, rituals, conversations in their head, and values they carry forward. The relationship changes shape. It doesn't have to end.

For example: A teenager wears her grandfather's watch to exams. She doesn't believe in luck. It just feels like he's with her.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"What would they say about this?" "I carry this part of them with me."

TRY THIS:

Choose one way to keep a bond: cook their recipe, tell a story about them, or keep one of their habits.

07

Big changes are losses too, even the good ones.

A new baby, a promotion, retirement, moving country, a child starting school, coming out, or getting well after a long illness can all bring grief for the old life. Change often has three parts: an ending, a confusing in-between time, and a new beginning. The middle part is the hardest, and the easiest to rush.

For example: A couple moves to a new city for a great job. Six months in, one of them feels low and guilty: "We wanted this." They also lost friends, a favourite café and a whole way of life.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"I can be glad about this and still miss what came before." "I'm in the in-between. It's supposed to feel unsettled."

TRY THIS:

For one change you're going through, write: what ended, what feels unclear, and one small thing that's new and good.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a change is hard to talk about, writing can come first. This is a quiet place to put the words down, at your own pace, and to send them only if you want to.

TOOL **Talk it through in writing** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

08

Most people find a way through, and support helps.

Research suggests that many people, over time, find they can live with a loss and still feel joy, even though they never forget. Being with people who let you talk, or not talk, helps. For some, though, grief stays stuck at full strength for a long time and makes daily life very hard.

Doctors call this **prolonged grief**: a strong longing for the person, or being taken over by the loss, most days, still going many months after the death (usually a year or more for adults) and getting in the way of life. That isn't weakness, and there is specific help for it.

For example: A year after his wife died, a man still can't go into their bedroom or see friends. His doctor refers him to a grief counsellor. Slowly, things begin to move.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"It's been a long time and it isn't getting any easier. I think I need more help."

TRY THIS:

Write down two people you could text on a hard day, and one place you could call if those people aren't enough.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control the loss, how long grief lasts, or how other people react to it. You can control small things: eating something, resting, telling one person how you are, and saying no to what you can't manage right now. That is enough for a hard season. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SATURDAY, 9:40AM

You sit in the car for ten minutes and let the wave come. Then you go back in, and you buy the cereal. At home you text your sister: "Saw Dad's cereal in the shop and cried in the car park." She replies straight away: "Same thing happened to me with his aftershave. Call tonight?" The wave doesn't mean you're back at day one. It means he's still part of your Saturdays.

Losing a partner in later life

After a long marriage, the loss is in everything: the empty chair, the jobs that were always theirs, the paperwork done alone, the first birthday and anniversary without them. Do one small thing at a time. One drawer counts. Ask someone to sit with you for the forms.

Your grown-up children have lost a parent, and you have lost a partner. You may grieve on different timetables. If they start checking on you every day, that comes from love and worry, not control. You can still say what helps: "I love that you ring. Could we make it two evenings a week, and I'll ring you if I need you?"

In everyday life

- **Partners:** After a miscarriage, one partner wants to talk and the other goes quiet. Each worries the other doesn't care.
- **Parents and children:** A child laughs and plays the day after a funeral, then cries at bedtime. Both are grief.
- **Friends:** A friend stops calling after your diagnosis, not from coldness but because they don't know what to say.
- **Work:** A colleague returns after a death and everyone avoids the subject. She feels her loss has been erased.
- **Community:** A neighbourhood loses its library, or a town loses its factory, and many people grieve the same thing together.

On your own: carrying it gently

Grief can be lonely, even with people around. Some things help when you're carrying it alone:

- Give the day a small shape: one meal, one walk, one person you message.

- Expect harder days around dates, and plan something gentle for them.
- Write to who you lost, or about what you lost. Nobody else needs to read it.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
"I don't have to do this fast." "Today I only need to get to tonight."

IF SOMEONE CLOSE TO YOU HAS DIED: Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief) goes further, with family after a loss, coming back to people, and a new chapter on your own. On a heavy night, try For a hard evening.

Common mix-ups

- **"There are five stages, in order."** Most people go back and forth. There is no correct order.
- **"After a year you should be over it."** Grief changes over time, but there's no deadline. Anniversaries and birthdays often bring it back.
- **"If I'm not crying, I'm not grieving."** Some people grieve by doing, thinking or staying busy. That counts.
- **"Moving on means forgetting."** You can build a new life and keep a bond with who you lost.
- **"Good changes shouldn't make me sad."** Every change ends something. Missing the old life is normal.
- **"I shouldn't mention their name, it'll upset them."** Many grieving people say hearing the name is a comfort. Ask.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Show up, and keep showing up.** Support often floods in for two weeks and then stops. A text at three months, or on a birthday, can mean a great deal.
- **Offer something specific.** "Can I drop off dinner on Thursday?" is easier to say yes to than "let me know if you need anything."
- **Say the name.** Share a memory. Let them talk, or not.
- **Don't fix or explain.** Skip "everything happens for a reason" and "at least…". Try "I'm so sorry. I'm here."
- **Comfort in, vent out.** If you're upset too, lean on people further from the loss, not on those closest to it.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't know what to say, but I'm here." "I was thinking about your mum today. I remember her laugh." "I'm going to the shop, what can I bring you?"

When to get more help

Grief is not an illness. But it's worth talking to a doctor or a grief counsellor if, after many months, the pain isn't easing at all, you can't manage daily life, you feel life has no meaning without the person, or you are drinking or using other things to get through. Many hospices, faith communities and charities offer free bereavement support, including for children.

If you are having thoughts of not wanting to be here, please tell someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

If a loss involved violence, or you are grieving a relationship you left because you weren't safe, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help, including after you separate.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) for a wave that feels too big

Reading pages to read on the website

- Calm sounds (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) for a quiet few minutes
- Grief and later life: loss, family and a new chapter, with a page for a hard evening
- Grief and change (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions) and ambiguous loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life), in the site's library of research notes
- Moving and life transitions and writing about hard things
- After a loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path), in your self-discovery path

More for your situation

- **After a breakup or divorce:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- **Families after a loss:** Grief and family · Family rifts after a loss or a will (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- **Children and teens:** Helping children grieve · For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)

- **Big changes:** Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · Retired together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together) · Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · New parent (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- **Illness and caring:** When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- **Friendships:** When a friendship drifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **More in Part Three:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-7-worth) · Minds that work differently (page 55)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Grief is love with nowhere to go.** It hurts because the person, place or life mattered.
- ✓ **It comes in waves, not stages.** A good week and then a bad day is normal, not going backwards.
- ✓ **You don't have to let go.** Many people keep a bond with the person they lost, and that's healthy.
- ✓ **Most people find a way through.** Support helps, and some losses need more help. Both are normal.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · Attachment, trust and belonging
Why losing a bond hurts so much page 7

Book 3 · Helping others well
Supporting someone who is grieving Share the Load

Chapter 5 · Worry, low mood and trauma
When grief turns into low mood page 81

Book 1 · Where your lens came from
Losses that shaped your lens Know Yourself Kindly

PUT IT TO USE

Upset right now?
For a wave that feels too big
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Calm sounds
For a quiet few minutes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-8-loss-in-depth

4

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 4 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 9

Minds that work differently

How autistic, ADHD, sensory and learning differences work, why they are differences and not character flaws, and how people with different minds can meet in the middle.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Brains vary, like bodies do
2. Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting
3. ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it
4. Everyone has a sensory profile
5. Learning differences aren't about intelligence
6. Masking costs energy
7. Autistic burnout is more than being tired
8. Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices
9. Stimming helps, so let it be
10. Deep focus makes switching hard
11. Deep interests are a source of joy and rest
12. Meet in the middle, out loud
13. Labels are tools, and they belong to the person
14. Finding out later in life
15. Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own
16. When demands feel like a threat
17. Not recognising faces isn't rudeness
18. Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say
19. Telling friends and dates is your choice
20. Finding your people
21. In everyday life
22. Common mix-ups
23. If you want to help someone else with this
24. When to get more help
25. Tools and reading on this site
26. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Brains vary, like bodies do.** Different isn't broken, and differences can still be disabling in a world built for one kind of mind.

- **Overload isn't a choice.** Meltdowns, shutdowns and burnout are what happens when a nervous system has had too much.
- **Some things help a lot:** less masking, room to stim, time for deep interests, and real rest.
- **Meet in the middle, out loud.** Ask what helps, say what helps you, and use the words each person chooses.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **The Wiring Card and "know how you like to be spoken to"** (Part One, Now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)) work because different minds need different input. Saying things plainly is an adjustment that helps almost everyone. Big idea: *tune how you send and receive.*
- **One owner per job and the written job list** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) move memory out of anyone's head and onto paper. That helps ADHD and autistic minds most, and everyone a little. Big idea: *fix the setup, not the person.*

MONDAY, 8:15AM

"Can you just put your shoes on?" For the third time. Your child is lying on the hall floor, hands over his ears, because the new socks "feel wrong." You're late. He's not being difficult. To him, the sock seam feels like sandpaper, and the alarm clock is still ringing in his head.

This chapter is for anyone: neurodivergent people, diagnosed or not, and the people who live, work and learn with them. It explains

how these minds work first, then what helps. It can't diagnose anyone, and only you get to choose the labels you use for yourself.

01

Brains vary, like bodies do.

People's brains differ in how they take in the world, focus, move, read, remember and connect with others. "Neurodiversity" is the idea that this variety is natural. "Neurodivergent" describes people whose minds work differently from what is treated as typical. Different isn't broken. And at the same time, differences can be disabling, especially when the world is built for one kind of mind.

For example: A man who struggled all through school finds out at 40 that he is dyslexic. He's relieved: he was never lazy or stupid. His brain just processes written words differently.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "Maybe this isn't a flaw. Maybe it's a difference that needs a different setup."

> TRY THIS:
> Think of one thing that's hard for you that's easy for others. Ask: is it effort, or is it a different kind of brain?

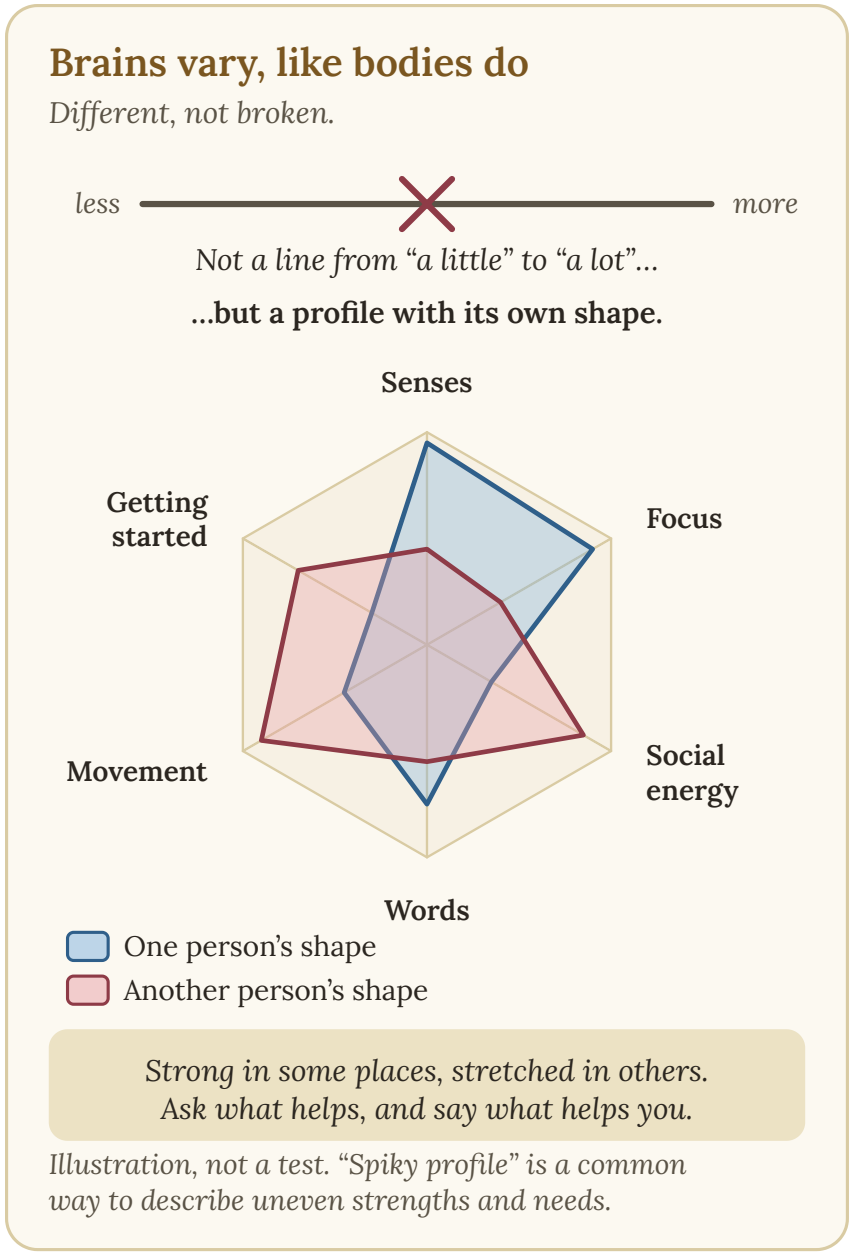


FIGURE 5 Brains vary, like bodies do. A mind has a profile with its own shape, not a place on a line from "a little" to "a lot". Different, not broken.

02

Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting.

Autistic people often communicate more directly and literally, have deep and focused interests, feel senses more (or less) intensely, and find predictability calming. Autism isn't a line from "mild" to "severe." Each autistic person has their own mix of strengths and needs, which can change day to day. Misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people usually run both ways.

For example: An autistic coworker says, "Your slides have three typos." She means it as help. Her colleague hears criticism. Neither is wrong; they're using different rules for what kind means.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I like it when people say exactly what they mean. You can be direct with me." "Do you want my honest view, or just support right now?"

> TRY THIS:
> In one conversation today, say exactly what you mean, with no hints. Notice whether it makes things easier.

03

ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it.

People with ADHD often have plenty of attention, but find it hard to point it where they choose. Boring tasks can feel impossible; interesting ones can swallow hours. Time can feel slippery ("now" and "not now"), and feelings can come fast and big. It's a real difference in how the brain manages itself, not a lack of effort or care.

For example: A woman with ADHD forgets her friend's birthday, then spends six hours making her an amazing handmade card. The forgetting and the focus come from the same brain.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I care about this. My brain drops things. A reminder really helps, and it doesn't annoy me."

TRY THIS:

Move one thing you keep forgetting out of your head and into the world: an alarm, a note on the door, or a basket by the exit.

04

Everyone has a sensory profile.

We all take in sound, light, touch, smell, taste, movement and signals from inside the body. Some people feel these strongly and get overloaded by noise or scratchy clothes. Others need more input: movement, strong flavours, pressure. Overload isn't being fussy. It's a body at its limit.

For example: Two housemates argue about the kitchen radio. One finds silence eerie; the other finds the radio painful. A rule helps: radio on mornings, headphones in the evening.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"It's not you. The noise in here is too much for me right now. Can we move somewhere quieter?"

TRY THIS:

Notice one sound, light or texture that drains you, and one that calms you. Make one small change today.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Knowing your own sensory profile is useful information, not a complaint. A one-page card lets you share what helps, in your own words.

TOOL **How I like to be spoken to: a one-page card** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

05

Learning differences aren't about intelligence.

Dyslexia (reading and spelling), dyscalculia (numbers), dyspraxia (coordination and planning movement) and language disorders are specific differences, not a measure of how clever someone is. Many people have a "spiky" profile: very strong in some areas, struggling in others. The right tools, like audiobooks, spoken notes or extra time, can level the ground.

For example: A teenager with dyspraxia is called clumsy at football. In drama, he writes and directs the school play. Same boy, different task.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I learn better when I can listen than when I read. Could you send a voice note instead?"

> TRY THIS:
> Ask someone you live or work with: "What's the easiest way for you to take in information?" Then use it.

06

Masking costs energy.

Many neurodivergent people learn to hide their differences: copying others, forcing eye contact, holding back movements, rehearsing small talk. This is called masking. It can help someone get through a day, but it uses a lot of energy, and over years it can lead to exhaustion, anxiety and burnout.

For example: A student seems fine all day at college, then comes home and can't speak for an hour. She's not being rude. She's recovering from a day of performing.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I need some quiet time after work. It's how I recharge, not a sign I'm upset with you."

TRY THIS:

Notice one place where you can drop the mask a little, and one person you can be fully yourself with. Spend a bit more time there.

07

Autistic burnout is more than being tired.

Autistic burnout is a deep, long-lasting exhaustion. Working with autistic adults, Raymaker and colleagues (2020) described it as long-term exhaustion, loss of skills (like speech, planning or self-care) and lower tolerance of noise, light and other input. It comes from long stress without enough support, and often lasts months. Rest, fewer demands and less masking help. Pushing harder usually makes it worse.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm in burnout. I need fewer demands for a while, not a pep talk." "I can't do phone calls at the moment. Can we message instead?"

TRY THIS:

If you think you might be in burnout, list three demands you could drop, delay or share for a month. If it goes on, or you feel hopeless, talk to a doctor.

08

Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices.

A **meltdown** is an involuntary loss of control when overwhelm gets too much: crying, shouting, running off or lashing out. A **shutdown** is the quiet version: going still, losing speech, not being able to respond. Neither is a tantrum. In interviews by Phung and colleagues (2021), autistic young people described meltdowns and shutdowns as separate experiences, both linked to overload. What helps is less: less noise, fewer words, fewer questions, more space and safety. Talking can wait.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> (to someone else) "You're safe. I'm right here. No need to talk."
> (for yourself) "I'm overloaded. I need quiet for twenty minutes."

> TRY THIS:
> On a calm day, agree a simple signal for "I'm overloaded" and a quiet place to go.

09

Stimming helps, so let it be.

Stimming means repeated movements or sounds, like rocking, flapping, tapping, humming, pacing or fiddling with something. Most people stim a little (think of a jiggling foot). For many autistic people it matters a lot. In interviews by Kapp and colleagues (2019), autistic adults described stimming as a way to cope with overwhelming emotions and sensations, and objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming. If it isn't hurting anyone, it doesn't need stopping.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Rocking helps me think. It doesn't mean anything's wrong."
> "You don't need to stop. It's fine with me."

TRY THIS:

Notice what your own hands or body do when you're stressed, focused or happy. That's your stim.

10

Deep focus makes switching hard.

Some minds, often autistic and ADHD ones, focus deeply on one thing at a time. That focus can be a gift: real expertise, flow and joy. It also makes switching tasks hard, so being interrupted can feel like being pulled out of water. Warnings before a change, and routines, help a lot.

For example: A dad calls his daughter to dinner three times and gets more frustrated each time. Then he tries a ten-minute warning, and a five. She comes to the table calm.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Dinner is in ten minutes. I'll come and get you at five to." "Can you give me a warning before we switch?"

TRY THIS:

Before you interrupt someone who's focused, give a heads-up and a time. See if it goes more smoothly.

11

Deep interests are a source of joy and rest.

Many autistic people have deep, intense interests, often called special interests. The theory of monotropism (Murray, Lesser and Lawson, 2005) describes autistic attention as pulled strongly into a few things at a time. In a survey of autistic adults by Grove and colleagues (2018), people who were more motivated by and engaged with their special interests reported higher wellbeing, though very intense engagement went with lower wellbeing.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can I tell you about this for five minutes? It's how I unwind."
"Tell me more. What's the best bit?"

TRY THIS:

Ask someone about their favourite subject, and let them talk for five minutes without steering.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: this site can change to fit your mind too, with bigger text, calmer pages and fewer surprises. Ooh, try it!

TOOL **Make the site fit your mind** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

12

Meet in the middle, out loud.

When two kinds of mind live or work together, neither should have to do all the adjusting. Clear, explicit words help everyone: say what you mean, give times, write things down, ask what helps. Changes made for one person, like quiet spaces, written agendas or flexible hours, often help many others too.

For example: A team starts sending meeting agendas a day early. It was for one autistic colleague. Soon everyone says meetings are shorter and better.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"What would make this easier for you?" "Here's what helps me. What helps you?"

TRY THIS:

Swap one "how I work best" fact with someone today: one thing that helps you, and ask for one that helps them.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

Wiring Card for work

Tom, autistic, for his new manager

Your card

Who it's for

A partner · Family · A friend · *Work (a manager or coworker)*

Name on the card, optional

Tom

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

How I receive things best
A written list.

I take words
Literally.

Give me time to answer
Write it down so I can answer later.

Please avoid
A hard topic with no warning. Correcting me in public.

A request lands best as
"Could you ___ by ___?"

Also good to know about me
If I go quiet, I'm processing, not upset. Tell me the plan, and tell me if it changes. Noise, light or touch can wear me out.

Sensory needs
Short breaks in long talks.

Sent with one line: "Here's a short card about how I work best. It's not a request for anything big; it just helps us avoid crossed wires."

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Sharing a card is always the person's own choice.

Fill in your own: Wiring Card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card)

13

Labels are tools, and they belong to the person.

A diagnosis can bring understanding, support and community. Some people find their way to a label through self-discovery first. Many autistic adults prefer "autistic person"; others prefer "person with autism." The kindest rule is simple: ask, and use the words the

person chooses. And never try to diagnose someone else, especially in an argument.

For example: During a row, a partner says, "You're so autistic." It lands as an insult and ends the talk. Later, he apologises and asks what his partner actually needs.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"How do you like to describe yourself?" "I'm wondering if I might be neurodivergent. I'd like to find out more."

TRY THIS:

If you've wondered about yourself, write down what you've noticed, and decide one small next step: reading, talking to someone, or asking a doctor.

14

Finding out later in life.

More and more adults are finding out they are autistic, or have ADHD, in their thirties, fifties or seventies. Many were missed as children, especially women. In interviews by Leedham and colleagues (2020), women diagnosed at forty or older described how exhausting it had been to go so long without an explanation, and how much the diagnosis changed how they understood their lives. Relief, grief and joy can all come together.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I've just found out I'm autistic. I'm still working out what it means." "That explains so much about my life."

TRY THIS:

If you've found out later in life, look for one autistic-led group, book or online space, and give yourself time to make sense of it.

15

Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own.

Planning, starting, switching, remembering what you were doing and keeping track of time are called **executive function**. Many autistic and ADHD people find some of these harder, on some days more than others. A review of 235 studies by Demetriou and colleagues (2018) found differences in executive function in autism on average, with a lot of variation between people. It isn't laziness. It's the brain's self-management system working differently, and it often helps to move the managing out of your head and into the world.

For example: A woman can write a brilliant report but can't get herself to post a parcel. Putting the parcel by the door, with a sticky note and a phone alarm, gets it done.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Could you send me that as a list? Spoken steps fall out of my head." "I'm not ignoring it. Starting is the hard bit for me."

TRY THIS:

Pick one task that keeps not happening. Make the first step tiny and visible: a note, an alarm, or the thing left where you'll trip over it. See routines that help (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) and Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently).

16

When demands feel like a threat.

Some people, often autistic, feel strong anxiety when asked or expected to do things, even things they want to do. Avoiding the demand can look like refusing, joking, distracting or a meltdown. The profile was first described as "pathological demand avoidance," or PDA, by Newson and colleagues (2003).

It is not in the main diagnostic manuals, and researchers disagree about it: a review by Kildahl and colleagues (2021) found the evidence limited and mostly based on parent reports. Many people who identify with it prefer the phrase "persistent drive for autonomy." Whatever it is called, what helps tends to be the same: less pressure, more choice, and requests that feel like invitations.

For example: A boy who refuses "Put your coat on now" happily puts it on when his dad says, "It's cold out. Coat or jumper, your choice."

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I wonder if we could…" "No rush. Which would you rather?" (for yourself) "Being told makes it harder. Can I choose when?"

> TRY THIS:
> Turn one daily instruction into a choice or an invitation this week, and see what changes.

17

Not recognising faces isn't rudeness.

Prosopagnosia, or face blindness, means finding it hard to recognise people's faces, sometimes even close friends out of context. It can be something you're born with, and it often runs in families (NHS). Many autistic people also find remembering faces harder, as a review by Weigelt and colleagues (2012) found. People who don't recognise you may be relying on voices, hair, clothes or where they usually see you.

For example: A man walks past his neighbour in the supermarket without a word. She feels snubbed. Later he explains he didn't recognise her without her dog. Now she says hello first, with her name.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm bad with faces, so please say who you are when you say hi." (to someone else) "Hi, it's Jo from next door."

TRY THIS:

If faces are hard for you, tell one or two people you see often. If not, try saying your name when you greet someone out of context.

18

Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say.

Some autistic people speak rarely, sometimes, or not at all, and some lose speech when stressed. Many communicate through **AAC** (augmentative and alternative communication): typing, letter boards, picture cards, apps or sign. Using AAC doesn't stop speech developing; a review by Millar, Light and Schlosser (2006) found it did not hold speech back, and may help it. The safest starting point is to presume competence: assume the person understands and has something to say, and give them the time and tools to say it.

For example: At a family meal, a non-speaking teenager types on her tablet. Her uncle used to talk about her in front of her. Now he waits, reads her reply, and answers her directly.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Take your time. I'll wait." "Would you rather type or point?" (for yourself) "I can't talk right now. I can type."

TRY THIS:

Talk to the person, not about them. Wait longer than feels natural for an answer.

19

Telling friends and dates is your choice.

Whether to tell someone you're autistic or ADHD, and when, is up to you. Telling can bring understanding: in a study by Sasson and Morrison (2019), people formed better first impressions of autistic adults when they knew they were autistic, especially if they knew more about autism.

But people don't always respond well, and interviews by Au-Yeung and colleagues (2025) describe autistic adults weighing hope for support against fear of not being believed. Many people share a little at a time, starting with what helps rather than a label.

For example: On a second date, a woman says, "I'm autistic, so I'm pretty direct, and I'd rather walk than sit in a loud bar." Her date says, "Honestly, same."

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm autistic. For me that means…" "I won't always pick up hints, so please just tell me." (if someone shares with you) "Thanks for telling me. What helps?"

> TRY THIS:
> Write one sentence about what helps you, without a label. Practise it. You can add the label later if and when you want to.

20

Finding your people.

Many autistic people describe finding other autistic people as a turning point: not having to translate, explain or mask. Research backs this up. Cooper, Smith and Russell (2017) found that autistic people who felt more connected to other autistic people had higher self-esteem, and through that, less anxiety and depression. Being autistic can be an identity and a community, not only a diagnosis.

For example: After a late diagnosis, a man joins an online group for autistic adults who love maps. For the first time, a conversation doesn't tire him out.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"There are people who work like me." "I can belong somewhere without masking."

TRY THIS:

Look for one autistic-led group, book, podcast or online space about something you love.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't change how your brain, or anyone else's, is wired. You can learn how yours works, say what helps, and ask others what helps them. Meeting in the middle means both people move a little. If you're always the one adjusting, it's fair to say so. More in Part One: who you are today

MONDAY, 8:30AM

You stop asking. You sit on the hall floor next to him and say quietly, "Socks feel wrong?" He nods. You switch off the alarm clock that's still beeping in the bedroom and fetch the old seamless pair. Two minutes later his shoes are on. You're ten minutes late, and nobody shouted. That evening you order three more pairs of the seamless socks, and he chooses the colours.

In everyday life

On your own

Knowing how your mind works helps you build a life that fits it, and spot burnout early. See Get to know your wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path).

- **With a partner:** Swap "how I work best" notes: how you like plans, messages, touch and time alone. See Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships).
- **Parents and children:** Behaviour often has a sensory or overload reason. Ask "What's too much right now?" before "Why are you doing this?"
- **With friends:** A friend who cancels at the last minute may be out of energy, not out of care. Offer easy options, like a walk or a message.
- **At work:** Written agendas, clear deadlines and quiet spaces help many people, not only neurodivergent ones. See Neurodiversity at work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **If you have ADHD and share a home:** Make the chore tools lighter. Log three days, not seven, with a tally on the fridge. Own a few jobs completely, each with a labelled alarm, instead of helping a bit with everything. Forgetting is a setup problem to fix together. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

- **"Everyone's a bit autistic."** Everyone has some traits in common, but autism is a whole pattern, present across life. The phrase can make real needs sound small.
- **"ADHD just means you can't sit still."** Many people with ADHD, especially girls and women, are mostly inattentive or restless on the inside.
- **"They seem fine to me."** Masking can hide a lot. Seeming fine isn't the same as being fine.
- **"Adjustments are special treatment."** They remove barriers so people can do what's expected. Glasses aren't special treatment either.
- **"Autistic people lack empathy."** Many feel others' feelings strongly. Differences in how empathy is shown run both ways.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Believe them** about what's hard, what hurts and what helps, even if it's different for you.
- **Be clear.** Say what you mean, give times, and write down anything important.
- **Ask, don't assume.** Every neurodivergent person is different. "What helps you?" beats any list.
- **Protect their energy.** Quiet time, warnings before changes and a way out of loud places aren't extras.
- **Enjoy their interests.** Listening to someone talk about what they love is one of the warmest things you can do.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Is there anything about this place, or this plan, that would make it hard for you?" "You don't have to explain. Just tell me what you need."

When to get more help

If you wonder whether a difference is part of ongoing difficulties at school, work or home, for you or someone you care for, a doctor, school support staff or a psychologist can talk you through an assessment. Waiting lists can be long, so start early and write down what you notice.

Burnout, depression and anxiety are more common among neurodivergent people, often because of the stress of living in a world that doesn't fit. If you're exhausted most days, losing skills you used to have, or feeling hopeless, please talk to a doctor. **If you are having thoughts of hurting yourself,** please tell someone today.

In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.

A difference never excuses harm, and it never makes someone deserve harm. If someone uses your differences to control or belittle you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz) for a friendly look at how you send and receive words

Reading pages to read on the website

- The wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card): a one-page "how I communicate" card to share
- Wired differently: neurodiversity and communication, including the double empathy problem
- Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself)
- Research notes: autism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), ADHD, monotropism, masking, sensory profiles and sensory load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress)

More for your situation

- **Couples:** Neurodivergent relationships
- **Parents and grandparents:** When a child has ADHD · Neurodivergent families
- **At work:** Neurodiversity at work · Autistic at work
- **Teens:** For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Sharing a home:** Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- **On your own:** Get to know your wiring · Part One: who you are today
- **More in Part Three:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-7-worth) · Loss, grief and big life changes (page 39)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

FOR AUTISTIC READERS. If you're autistic, or wondering, these are written with you in mind: masking and autistic burnout earlier in this chapter; the double empathy problem, on why misunderstandings run both ways; when feelings are hard to name (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings-in-depth) (alexithymia) in Chapter 1; the wiring card, a one-page "how I work best" card to share; and Autistic at work, with words for asking for what you need.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Brains vary, like bodies do.** Different isn't broken, and differences can still be disabling in a world built for one kind of mind.
- ✓ **Overload isn't a choice.** Meltdowns, shutdowns and burnout are what happens when a nervous system has had too much.
- ✓ **Some things help a lot:** less masking, room to stim, time for deep interests, and real rest.
- ✓ **Meet in the middle, out loud.** Ask what helps, say what helps you, and use the words each person chooses.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1 · Your wiring, weather and words
Getting to know your own wiring — Know Yourself Kindly

Book 2 · Why we get out of tune
Pace, tone and meeting in the middle — Closer, Together

Book 1 · Personality, temperament and change
Dials, not boxes — Know Yourself Kindly

Book 2 · How communication works
Saying it so it lands for different minds — Closer, Together

PUT IT TO USE



Communication style quiz
For a friendly look at how you send and receive words
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz`



The wiring card
A one-page "how I communicate" card to share
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card`



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds-in-depth`

5

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 5 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 16

Worry, low mood and trauma

How worry and anxiety work, the difference between a low patch and depression, what trauma is and isn't, what helps day to day, how to support someone, and when and where to get more help. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm
2. Avoiding keeps fear going
3. Give worry a time and a place
4. Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week
5. Doing often comes before feeling better
6. Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work
7. Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind
8. After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure
9. Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Worry, low mood and the after-effects of trauma are common, human and treatable.** They are not weakness, and they are not your fault.
- **They all run through the stress system** from Chapter 2 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress). Small, steady things that settle the body and reconnect you with life help more than big pushes.

- **Avoiding and withdrawing feel safer but keep things going.** Small steps back in, a little at a time, help most.
- **Talking therapies work for many people, and so can medicines.** If it has lasted weeks, is getting in the way of life, or you feel unsafe, get help. If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (US) or call Samaritans on 116 123 (UK and Ireland) now.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **The daily check-in's "low, medium or high"** (Part Two, Chapter I (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1)) works because worry and low mood shrink the room you have. Saying so lets the people around you adjust. Big idea: *read your state first.*
- **"A full tank means later, not never"** (Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3)) names a time to come back, because avoiding a thing keeps fear going, and a named time doesn't.
- **Pick one small goal** (Part One, Next (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next)) fits low mood: doing often comes before feeling better.

SUNDAY, 10:50PM

The house is quiet. You've checked the front door twice. Tomorrow is the hospital appointment, and the same three thoughts go round: what if it's bad, what if I can't cope, what if there's nobody to tell. Your chest is tight and your mind won't stop. You haven't really wanted to see anyone for a few weeks either. Everything feels like too much effort.

Almost everyone worries, feels low or goes through something frightening at some point. For some people these feelings settle by themselves. For others they stick, grow and start to shape every day. This chapter explains how they work, what tends to help, and when it's time to ask for more help. It can't diagnose anyone. If any of this is about you right now, you are not alone, and things can get better.

01

Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm.

Fear is the body's alarm for danger that is here now. Anxiety is the same alarm ringing about something that might happen. Worry is the thinking part: "What if…?" on repeat. They use the same stress system as Chapter 2: a racing heart, tight chest, shallow breathing, a churning stomach, poor sleep. The alarm is trying to protect you. The trouble is that it can be set too sensitive, and it can't tell a real tiger from a worrying email.

For example: A teenager's heart pounds before every class presentation. Nothing bad has ever happened. Her alarm still treats a room of classmates like danger.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "This is my alarm, not a fact." "My body is getting ready to protect me. I can thank it and carry on."

> TRY THIS:
> When worry rises, breathe out slowly, longer out than in, five times. Then name three things you can see. It tells the body the danger isn't here right now.

02

Avoiding keeps fear going.

When something makes us anxious, stepping away brings quick relief. But the relief teaches the brain, "Good thing we escaped." Next time, the fear is a little bigger and the world a little smaller. What helps is the opposite: going back towards the feared thing in small, chosen steps, and staying long enough to learn that you can cope. Therapists call this exposure. Craske and colleagues (2014) describe how it works best when each step tests what you expect to happen.

For example: After a panic attack on a bus, a man starts walking everywhere. With his sister's help he takes one stop, then two, then a whole journey. The fear fades as his brain learns buses are survivable.

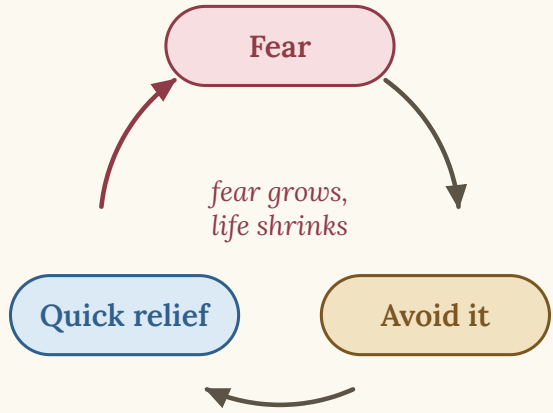
> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "What do I think will happen? Let's see what actually happens."
> "Uncomfortable isn't the same as dangerous."

TRY THIS:

Pick one small thing you've been avoiding. Break it into three steps, from easiest to hardest. Do the easiest one this week.

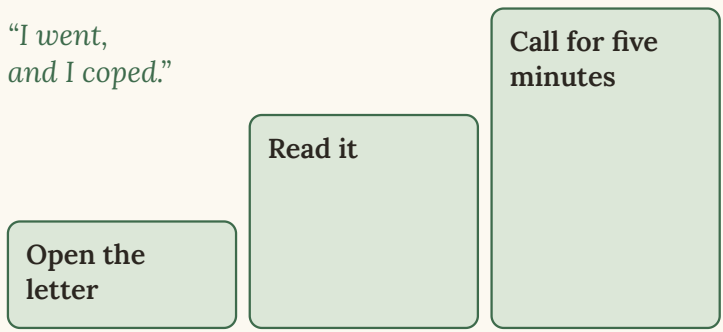
Avoiding keeps fear going

Quick relief now, a smaller life later.



The way back: small, planned steps

*"I went,
and I coped."*



Planned, gradual approach (exposure) is among the most effective treatments for anxiety; it builds new learning that competes with the old fear (Craske and colleagues, 2014). A therapist can help with strong fears.

FIGURE 6 Avoiding keeps fear going. Small, planned steps back in help most, and a therapist can help with strong fears.

03

Give worry a time and a place.

Trying hard not to worry rarely works. What helps many people is postponing it: noticing a worry, writing it down, and saving it for a set "worry time" later in the day. In an early study by Borkovec and colleagues (1983), people who practised this for four weeks reported worrying less each day. In worry time, sort each worry: is there something I can do? If yes, plan one step. If not, practise letting it go.

For example: A father caring for his own dad keeps a worry notebook by the kettle. At 6pm he gives it fifteen minutes. Many of the morning's worries already look smaller.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Noted. I'll think about that at six." "Can I do anything about this today? If not, it can wait."

TRY THIS:

Choose a fifteen-minute worry time, not just before bed. Keep a note on your phone for worries that pop up in between.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

Flip it

Tolu, 17, at 1am, three days before an exam

Flip it

What's on your mind?

What if I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want?

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone | A *worry* | Being hard on myself | Anger

THE FLIP

The best outcome would be
[what you hope for]

The main thing in the way
I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want

If that happens, I'll
[one small thing you could do]

One step today
[something that takes ten minutes or less]

This is WOOP, from Gabriele Oettingen's research: Wish, Outcome, Obstacle, Plan. The worry becomes the obstacle you plan for. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Tolu's version
Best outcome: I pass, and I feel I did my best. In the way: I freeze on the long questions. If that happens, I'll do the short questions first and come back. One step today: one long question from a past paper, then bed.

When the worry comes back at 1am
It goes on the list for tomorrow's worry time, 5pm, ten minutes.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. If worry is stopping you sleeping or eating most days, tell someone you trust, or your doctor.

Fill in your own: Flip it (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

04

Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week.

Everyone has low days, and sadness after a loss or a disappointment is normal. Depression is different: low mood, or losing interest in things you used to enjoy, most of the day, nearly every day, for two weeks or more, often with poor sleep, tiredness, changes in appetite, feeling worthless or guilty, and finding it hard

to think. It can look like sadness, or like irritability, numbness or just running on empty. It is a health problem, not a character flaw.

For example: A retired teacher notices he has stopped going to his walking group, isn't reading, and wakes at four every morning. He tells himself he's just old. His daughter gently suggests it might be depression, and that it's treatable.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I've not been myself for a few weeks, and I don't think it's just tiredness." "I don't enjoy things I used to. Can I talk to you about it?"

TRY THIS:
If you've felt low or lost interest most days for two weeks or more, book a talk with a doctor this week. Write down what you've noticed to take with you.

05

Doing often comes before feeling better.

Low mood says, "Wait until you feel like it." But withdrawing makes life emptier, which deepens the low. A well-tested approach called behavioural activation turns this round: plan small, doable things that bring a bit of pleasure, meaning or achievement, and do them whether you feel like it or not. A review of 26 trials by Ekers and colleagues (2014) found it helped with depression, though many of the studies were small.

For example: A woman living alone after her divorce plans three small things a day: a ten-minute walk, one call or message, one task she can finish. Some days they feel pointless. Over a few weeks, the days start to feel less flat.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
"I don't have to feel like it to do it." "Small counts."

TRY THIS:

Write down three tiny things for tomorrow: one for pleasure, one for connection, one you can finish. Tick them off, however small.

06

Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work.

These sound too simple to matter, but the evidence for them is solid. Improving sleep can lift mood: in a large trial with university students, Freeman and colleagues (2017) found that an online sleep course reduced insomnia, and with it some other mental health difficulties.

Exercise helps depression too: a review of 218 trials by Noetel and colleagues (2024) found walking or jogging, yoga and strength training all helped. And belonging to groups protects: Cruwys and colleagues (2013) found that people with depression who joined groups were less likely to relapse.

For example: A new dad, exhausted and flat, agrees with his partner on one protected long sleep each weekend each, a pram walk every morning, and a weekly game of five-a-side.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I need help protecting my sleep for a while." "Would you come for a short walk with me? I find it hard to go on my own."

TRY THIS:

Pick the one basic that is most off for you right now, sleep, moving or people, and make one small change to it this week.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Small, steady things help: a walk, a regular bedtime, time with someone kind. Calm sounds can be a soft way to wind down at night.

TOOL **Calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

07

Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind.

Trauma usually means going through, or seeing, something that threatened life or safety, such as violence, abuse, a serious accident, war, or the sudden death of someone close. It is very common: in surveys across 24 countries, Kessler and colleagues (2017) found about 7 in 10 adults had been through at least one.

Most people recover over time. A smaller number develop post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), with memories that come back vividly, avoiding reminders, feeling on high alert, and sleep problems. Ordinary hard times and stress hurt too, even when they aren't trauma in this sense.

For example: Months after a car crash, a woman still jumps at screeching brakes and avoids driving at night. She isn't "overreacting." Her alarm learned that cars can mean danger, and hasn't unlearned it yet.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"My reactions make sense after what happened." "It's in the past, even if my body doesn't feel that yet."

TRY THIS:

If something frightening happened more than a month ago and it still shapes your days, talk to a doctor. Trauma-focused talking therapies help many people.

08

After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure.

After a frightening event, people need safety, practical help, warmth and choice. They don't need to be made to talk. In fact, a review of single-session "debriefing" after trauma by Rose and colleagues (2002) found it did not prevent PTSD, and might make things worse for some. Services that are "trauma-informed" (SAMHSA, 2014) put safety, trust, choice and working together first. The same ideas help in families, friendships and workplaces.

For example: After a break-in, a grandmother doesn't want to talk about it. Her grandson doesn't push. He fixes the lock, stays the night, and says, "If you ever want to talk about it, I'm here." A week later, she does.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"You don't have to tell me anything. What would help right now?" "You're safe now. I'm staying."

TRY THIS:

If someone you love has been through something frightening, ask one practical question ("What do you need today?") and one open one ("How are you doing, really?"), and let them choose.

09

Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too.

Cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) teaches practical ways to notice and change patterns of thinking and doing. It is one of the most studied talking therapies: a review of over a hundred meta-analyses by Hofmann and colleagues (2012) found the strongest

support for anxiety problems and stress, and support for many other problems too.

Guidelines such as NICE (2022) also recommend guided self-help, behavioural activation, exercise groups and, for some people, antidepressants. Questions about medicine, including starting, changing or stopping it, are for a doctor or prescriber. Please don't stop a medicine suddenly without advice.

For example: A young man is embarrassed to ask for help with panic attacks. His GP refers him to a short course of CBT. Eight sessions later, he's back on the train to work.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I'd like to talk about my mood. It's been going on for a while."
"What are my options, and what do you recommend for someone like me?"

TRY THIS:
Write three lines before an appointment: what you've noticed, how long, and what it's stopping you doing. It makes the first conversation easier.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn how your alarm works, keep the basics going, take small steps back towards life, and ask for help when it's more than you can carry. You can't think your way out of depression by trying harder, and you can't fix someone else's. Being kind to yourself, and getting the right help, are part of the work, not a failure at it. If you feel unsafe, reaching out today matters more than anything in this book.

MONDAY, 7:30AM

Last night you wrote the three worries on the back of an envelope and told them: tomorrow. You slept, a bit. This morning you breathe out long at the kitchen window, then text your neighbour: "Hospital at ten. A bit scared. Fancy a cuppa after?"

She replies with three hearts and "Of course." The appointment is still the appointment. But you're not facing it alone, and you've noticed something: it's been weeks of feeling flat. You add a line to the envelope: "Ask the doctor about my mood too."

If you're a teenager

Exams, friends, group chats and the future can all pile up, often at 1am. A *made-up example*: Tolu, 17, can't sleep before a chemistry exam. She writes the worry down for tomorrow's ten-minute worry time, plans one small step, and puts her phone in another room. The next day she tells her mum, and it helps more than she expected.

If worry or low mood is stopping you sleeping, eating or going to school most days for a few weeks, tell someone you trust or your doctor. Under 19 in the UK, you can call Childline free on 0800 1111.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I keep worrying at night. Can I talk it through?" "I don't need you to fix it. I just need to say it."

In everyday life

- **On your own:** Living alone can make worry louder at night and low mood quieter and easier to miss. A daily small contact, a

call, a message, a walk with someone, protects you. See On your own: when it's lonely (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

- **With a partner:** Low mood can look like not caring; anxiety can look like nagging. Name it: "I'm low, not cross with you." See Chapter 2 on stress in two people.
- **Parents and children:** Children and teens get anxious and low too. Calm, routine and listening help more than reassurance on repeat. See For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) and For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens).
- **With friends and family:** A friend who keeps cancelling may be struggling, not drifting. Keep inviting, with no pressure. See When a friend goes quiet (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **After a loss:** Grief and depression overlap but aren't the same. See Chapter 8 (page 39) and Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief).
- **At work:** Stress, worry and low mood are common at work and rarely spoken about. A short, honest line to a manager often opens up support. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **If you have ADHD:** Avoidance often looks like putting things off. Make the first step almost silly ("open the envelope"), set a ten-minute timer, or do it with someone else in the room. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-16-worry-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

- **"Anxiety means something is wrong with me."** Anxiety is a normal alarm. It becomes a problem when it's too loud, too often, or starts shrinking your life.
- **"Depression is just sadness. Snap out of it."** Depression affects sleep, energy, thinking and body as well as mood. Nobody snaps out of it, but many people recover with the right help.
- **"Everything bad that happens is trauma."** Trauma usually means threat to life or safety. Other hard things still hurt and still deserve care, and the word doesn't need to fit for help to be fair.
- **"Talking about trauma straight away helps everyone."** Some people want to talk, some don't. Forcing it can make things worse. Safety and choice come first.
- **"Asking someone about suicide puts the idea in their head."** It doesn't. A review by Dazzi and colleagues (2014) found no evidence that asking increases suicidal thoughts, and it may help.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Notice and ask.** "You've seemed low lately. How are you doing, really?" Then listen more than you talk.
- **Don't argue with the feeling.** "Cheer up" and "It could be worse" push people away. "That sounds really hard" keeps them close.
- **Offer something specific.** A walk, a meal, a lift to the doctor, sitting together. Small and practical beats big and vague.
- **Ask directly about safety if you're worried.** "Are you having thoughts of ending your life?" If yes, stay with them, and get

help together today.

- **Look after yourself too.** Supporting someone who is struggling is tiring. See Chapter 12 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm not trying to fix it. I just want you to know I'm here."
> "Would it help if I came with you to the doctor?"

When to get more help

Talk to a doctor, a counsellor or a mental health service if:

- you've felt low, empty or hopeless, or lost interest in things, most days for two weeks or more;
- worry or panic is stopping you doing things, or you're avoiding more and more;
- something frightening happened over a month ago and still shapes your days and nights;
- you're using alcohol, drugs, food or anything else to cope;
- you're not sleeping, eating or looking after yourself;
- you have thoughts of harming yourself.

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or you are in danger, get help now. Call your local emergency number (911 in the US and Canada, 999 in the UK, 112 in most of Europe). In the US, call or text 988, the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, or text HOME to 741741. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123, or text SHOUT to 85258.

In Canada, call or text 988. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Under 19 in the UK? Childline is free on 0800 1111. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines

in your country. More are on Someone to talk to, free (spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help).

In England you can usually refer yourself to NHS Talking Therapies without seeing a GP first. Find a counsellor or therapist has more places to start. If someone at home is hurting or frightening you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education. It isn't a diagnosis or a substitute for care from a professional.

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.
- Today's Weather (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks): a quick daily check-in on stress, sleep and people.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- The calm visualizer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer) for slow breathing.
- Help beyond this book: counsellors, helplines and support groups.
- The library: the stress response (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress), the window of tolerance, sleep and mood, going over and over things (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), catastrophising (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/

thinking) and loneliness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).

More for your situation

- On your own · Grief and later life
- For teens · For parents · New parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- At work
- Not safe at home?
- **More in Part Three:** Stress · Self-worth and self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-7-worth) · Healing (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Worry, low mood and the after-effects of trauma are common, human and treatable.** They are not weakness, and they are not your fault.
- ✓ **They all run through the stress system** from Chapter 2. Small, steady things that settle the body and reconnect you with life help more than big pushes.
- ✓ **Avoiding and withdrawing feel safer but keep things going.** Small steps back in, a little at a time, help most.
- ✓ **Talking therapies work for many people, and so can medicines.** If it has lasted weeks, is getting in the way of life, or you feel unsafe, get help. If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (US) or call Samaritans on 116 123 (UK and Ireland) now.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2 · Stress and the nervous system
The stress ladder and rest
Closer, Together

Book 1 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
A kinder inner voice
Know Yourself Kindly

Book 3 · Helping others well
Supporting someone who is struggling
Share the Load

Book 1 · Your wiring, weather and words
Checking your weather each day
Know Yourself Kindly

PUT IT TO USE



The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11



Upset right now?
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-16-worry-in-depth

6

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 6 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 17

Fitting in: groups, influence and culture

Why fitting in pulls so hard, how groups shape what we say and do, how culture and family set the unwritten rules, and how to stay yourself, and disagree kindly, without losing your place. For anyone in any group: a family, a friendship, a team, a faith, a neighbourhood or a group chat.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. The pull to fit in is old and strong
2. We go along more than we think
3. Authority can lead people a long way
4. "Us and them" forms fast
5. Norms are the rules nobody wrote down
6. Cultures differ, and so do people inside them
7. Every family is a small culture
8. Online groups pull harder and faster
9. You can belong and still be yourself
10. Disagree kindly, and early
11. If you're a teenager
12. In everyday life
13. Common mix-ups
14. If you want to help someone else with this
15. When to get more help
16. Reading on this site
17. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **The pull to fit in is old and strong.** Being left out hurts, so we bend to stay in. That's human, not weak.
- **Groups shape us more than we notice:** what we say, what we think is normal, and sometimes what we're willing to do.

- **Cultures and families each have unwritten rules.** They differ a lot, and so do the people inside them.
- **You can belong and still be yourself.** One calm, kind voice saying "I see it differently" often frees others to say so too.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **The rulebook from home** (Part One, Then (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then)) and **House rules for us** (One owner per job) write down the rules nobody wrote down, so a group can choose them instead of just following them. Big idea: *notice the quiet incentives.*
- **The monthly look-back** (Part Two, Chapter V (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5)) is "not a review of either person". That is what lets people speak up early, before the group drifts.

THURSDAY, 9:20PM

The family group chat is buzzing. Someone has posted a joke about your cousin's new partner, and the laughing faces are piling up. Your thumb hovers. You don't find it funny. You also don't want to be the one who "can't take a joke." Everyone else seems fine with it. You start typing a laughing face.

We all belong to groups, and we need them. Chapter 5 (page 7) looked at belonging: why we need each other and how trust grows. This chapter looks at the other side: how groups pull on us, why we go along, and how to stay true to yourself while staying connected.

01

The pull to fit in is old and strong.

For most of human history, being part of a group meant survival. Being left out still feels alarming. In studies by Williams and colleagues (2000), people who were simply left out of an online ball-throwing game, by strangers they would never meet, felt worse and less like they belonged. So we bend to stay in: laughing at jokes, keeping quiet, going along.

For example: A new starter at a warehouse laughs at a teasing nickname he dislikes, because he wants to be one of the team.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "Wanting to fit in is normal. I still get to choose what I go along with."

TRY THIS:
Notice one moment this week when you went along with something to fit in. No judging. Just notice.

02

We go along more than we think.

In Solomon Asch's famous experiments (Asch, 1956), people judged which of three lines matched another line. When the actors around them all gave the same wrong answer, people went along with the group on about a third of the answers, even though the right answer was obvious.

Many never went along at all. Later research, such as a review by Bond and Smith (1996), found the effect is real but varies: it has been smaller in more recent studies, and larger in cultures that put the group first.

For example: In a meeting, everyone praises a plan. One woman sees a big problem, but stays quiet. Afterwards, two colleagues tell

her they had doubts too.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

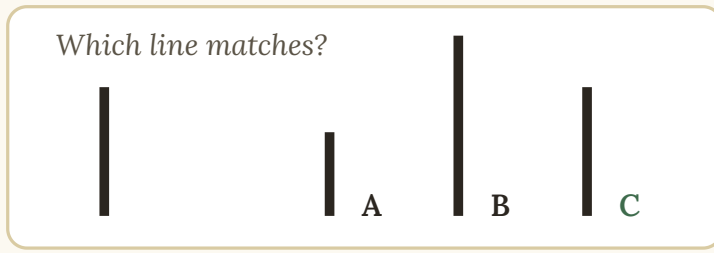
"Would I say this if I were on my own?" "If I'm thinking it, someone else might be too."

TRY THIS:

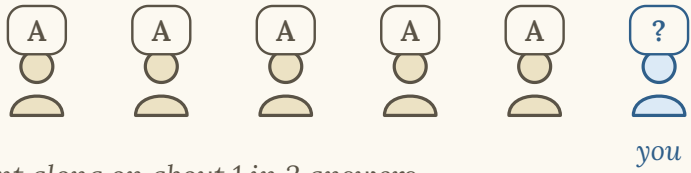
Before a group decision, write down your own view first. Then listen to the group.

We go along more than we think

And one other voice changes a lot.

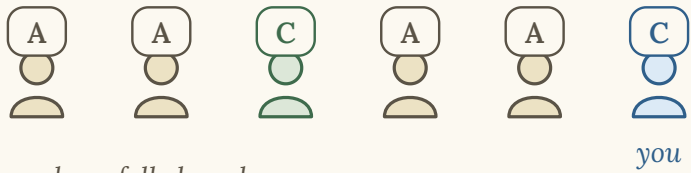


Alone against the group



went along on about 1 in 3 answers

With one ally



going along fell sharply

One calm, kind voice saying "I see it differently" often frees others to say so too.

Asch (1956). About a quarter of people never went along. Across 133 later studies the effect held but varied by time and culture (Bond and Smith, 1996).

FIGURE 7 We go along more than we think, and one other voice changes a lot. In Asch's studies, going along fell sharply when one other person gave the right answer.

03

Authority can lead people a long way.

In Stanley Milgram's experiments (Milgram, 1963), many ordinary people kept giving what they believed were painful electric shocks to a stranger, because a man in a lab coat told them to. (No shocks were real.) Burger (2009) repeated part of it safely and found similar results. But the studies are also debated: later researchers, such as Haslam and Reicher (2012), argue people went along when they believed in the cause, not blindly, and many people refused.

For example: A nurse is told by a senior doctor to give a dose that looks wrong. She checks, speaks up, and is right. Checking is not disloyalty.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Before I do this, can I check one thing?" "I'm not comfortable with this. Can we look at it again?"

TRY THIS:
Think of one person whose word you tend to follow without question. Is there anything you'd want to check next time?

04

"Us and them" forms fast.

Part of how we see ourselves comes from our groups: our family, town, team, faith or job. Tajfel and Turner (1979) called this social identity. It brings pride and loyalty. It also makes us quick to favour "us" and to see "them" as all the same, even when the groups are formed on almost nothing. Knowing that this happens is the first step to catching it.

For example: Two branches of a family always sit apart at weddings. Nobody quite remembers why. One year, a cousin swaps the seating plan, and the two sides discover they like the same terrible music.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Am I seeing a person, or a group?" "What do we have in common?"

TRY THIS:

Think of a "them" in your life. Name one person from that group as an individual: something they like, something they worry about.

05

Norms are the rules nobody wrote down.

Every group has norms: what you wear, how you speak, what you laugh at, what you never mention. We often guess the norms wrong. In studies at a university, Prentice and Miller (1993) found that most students were privately less comfortable with heavy drinking than they thought everyone else was. Each person thought they were the odd one out, so everyone kept going along.

For example: In an office, everyone answers emails at midnight because they think it's expected. When one manager says, "I don't expect replies after six," relief spreads.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Is this really what everyone thinks, or just what everyone does?"

TRY THIS:

Pick one unwritten rule in a group you're in. Ask one person, privately, what they really think of it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

House rules for us

Shona and her son Dexter, 15

House rules for us

Person A
Shona

Person B
Dexter

Date of this list
3 October 2026

Our rules, and who keeps each one

Rule	Who keeps it	Why it matters to Shona	Why it matters to Dexter
Phones charge in the kitchen from 10 on school nights	*Both (decide together)*	*I sleep better knowing you're not up at 2*	*Fine if it's both our phones, not just mine*
Homework before games, Monday to Thursday	*Dexter*	*Less nagging from me*	*Weekends are mine, then*
Say where you're going and when you'll be back	*Both (decide together)*	*So I don't worry*	*Mum does it too, so it's fair*
Friday tea together, no phones at the table	*Both (decide together)*	*It's my favourite hour of the week*	*Only if I can pick the food sometimes*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Rules with someone who keeps them
4 of 4. Every rule has someone who keeps it.

Changes to the list

Date	What changed	Who
3 Oct 2026	*Dexter asked for weekends without phone rules. Agreed for a month, then we look again.*	*Shona and Dexter*

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. The norms nobody wrote down, written down, with room for both of them to change them.

Fill in your own: House rules for us (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

06

Cultures differ, and so do people inside them.

Cultures differ in how much they put the individual or the group first. Researchers call this individualism and collectivism (Hofstede, 1980). In some, "standing out" is admired. In others, fitting in and keeping harmony are signs of maturity. Neither is better. But be careful with labels: a large review by Oyserman and colleagues (2002) found the differences were smaller and less tidy than often claimed, and individuals vary hugely within every culture.

For example: A woman raised in a close-knit family moves in with a partner who grew up encouraged to "do your own thing." He sees her daily calls home as clingy; she sees his rare calls as cold. Both are following the rules they learned.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Where I grew up, this was normal. What was normal for you?"

TRY THIS:

Name one thing you think of as simply "how people should behave." Where did you learn it? Might someone else have learned the opposite?

07

Every family is a small culture.

Families have their own norms: how loud people are, how feelings are shown, who does what, what's talked about and what isn't, how you say sorry, or if you do. We often only notice our family's rules when we live with someone from a different family. Part One looks at the rules you grew up with.

For example: Two housemates clash over the kitchen. In one's family, you wash up straight away. In the other's, you wash up in the morning. Neither is lazy or fussy; they grew up in different small cultures.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"In my family we always… What did yours do?" "Shall we make our own rule?"

TRY THIS:

Write three rules from the family you grew up in. Keep one you value, and question one you don't.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Family plan card

Amaka and Chris, new parents, with Chris's parents

Our family plan

A plan for the family, not a list of chores.

Who's in this plan (optional)
Amaka, Chris, Nana Joy and Grandad Pete

Visits
Sunday lunch every other week, 12 to 3. Text the day before.

Advice
Ask first: "Do you want ideas, or just to talk?"

The baby's or children's routines
Nap at 1. Back to sleep on her back, always. Ask us before any new food.

A regular job for a grandparent or relative
Grandad Pete does the Tuesday morning walk with the pram.

We'll look at this again on
The first Sunday of December

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Two family cultures, one plan written on purpose.

Fill in your own: Family plan card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins)

08

Online groups pull harder and faster.

Group chats, forums and social media make group pressure quicker and more public. Likes and replies show the norm instantly. In a study of over half a million posts, Brady and colleagues (2017) found that messages with more moral and emotional words spread further, mostly among people who already agreed. Outrage travels fast; quiet doubts don't.

For example: A parents' group chat turns against a teacher after one angry post. A dad who knows the teacher well sends a calm message: "I'd want to hear her side before we decide." Two others agree.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Would I say this to their face?" "The loudest posts aren't the whole group."

TRY THIS:

Before you react to a heated post, wait ten minutes. Then decide whether to reply, reply privately, or not reply at all.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: group chats move fast! Before you send a reply, a helper can read the room with you.

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator`

09

You can belong and still be yourself.

Belonging is being accepted as you are; fitting in is changing to be accepted (see Chapter 5 (page 7)). Good groups have room for difference. It helps to know your own values, to have more than one group, and to have at least one ally. In Asch's experiments, when just one other person gave the right answer, going along with the group dropped sharply.

For example: A teenager loves chess but his friends tease it as "nerdy." He joins a chess club as well as keeping his friends. With two groups, neither one can decide who he is.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Which groups let me be fully myself?" "Who would back me up if I spoke?"

TRY THIS:

Write down three things you value. Next time a group pulls you, check: is this in line with them?

10

Disagree kindly, and early.

You don't have to choose between going along and starting a war. A kind dissent is short, calm, about the issue rather than the people, and leaves room for others. Speaking early is easier than speaking late. And you don't have to do it in front of everyone: a private word often works better.

For example: Back to the group chat. Instead of a laughing face, you message your aunt privately: "I know it was meant as a joke, but it might hurt. Could we leave it?" She deletes it.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I see it a bit differently. Can I say why?" "I'm not comfortable with that joke." "I might be the only one, but I'd like us to think again." "Can we hear from people who haven't spoken yet?"

TRY THIS:

Choose one sentence from above that feels like you. Say it out loud a few times, so it's ready when you need it.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Disagreeing early and kindly is easier with the words ready. This workpaper helps you say it so it lands.



WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can notice the pull to fit in, check what you actually think, choose your groups, and say "I see it differently" kindly.

You can't control what a group does, and you don't have to stay in a group that keeps asking you to hide who you are or go against what's right. If a group, a family or a partner uses pressure, fear or threats to control you, that's not belonging. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

THURSDAY, 9:40PM

You delete the laughing face. Instead, you message your aunt, who posted the joke: "I know it was meant to be funny, but it might hurt if they see it. Could we leave it?" A few minutes later the joke disappears. Then your cousin messages you privately: "Thank you. I saw it before it went. Means a lot." Nobody fell out. The group is still the group. It just has a bit more room in it now.

If you're a teenager

Group chats are where a lot of friendship happens, and a lot of hurt. A *made-up example:* Rhys, 15, finds a photo of himself from PE being joked about in his class chat. He doesn't answer back.

He screenshots it, mutes the chat and tells his sister, and they tell his form tutor. Then a girl in his class messages him privately: "That wasn't funny. Sorry I didn't say anything." Most people in a group chat don't like what's happening. They just think everyone else does.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm not okay with this. Please delete it." To a friend: "That wasn't okay. Are you alright?" To an adult: "Something's happening online and I need help with it."

In everyday life

- **On your own:** Having no group can be as hard as having a pushy one. Look for groups built around something you enjoy, so the belonging comes with the activity. See Chapter 5 (page 7) and casual ties (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).
- **With a partner:** Two families, two sets of rules. Talk about them openly, and make your own. See family scripts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life).
- **Parents and children:** Children and teens feel peer pressure strongly. Help them practise a "no" that saves face. See For teens: friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens).
- **With family:** Old family roles (the joker, the peacekeeper, the black sheep) can be hard to step out of. See Old roles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts).
- **At work:** Teams where people feel safe to speak up make better decisions. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) and the library on teams (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/teams).
- **Online:** Mute, leave or take a break from groups that leave you feeling worse. You're allowed.
- **When everyone agrees too fast:** That's called groupthink. If you lead, share your view last and ask for one risk from each person before deciding. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-17-groups-in-depth).

- **Teams rarely in one room:** Write decisions down, go round everyone before deciding, and keep a short check-in so people at home aren't forgotten. More in the full chapter.

Common mix-ups

- **"Only weak people conform."** Everyone is influenced by groups. Knowing that makes you more free, not less.
- **"Milgram proved people will do anything they're told."** Many people refused, results varied a lot with the setup, and the studies have real critics. People seem most likely to go along when they believe in the cause.
- **"Culture explains everything about a person."** Culture shapes us, but people vary hugely within every culture. Ask the person, don't assume.
- **"Disagreeing will ruin the relationship."** Calm, kind disagreement often builds trust. Swallowing it for years tends to do more harm.
- **"Fitting in is the same as belonging."** Fitting in means changing to be accepted. Belonging means being accepted as you are.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Be the ally.** If someone speaks up, back them up, even quietly: "I think that's a fair point." One ally makes a big difference.
- **Make room.** In any group you lead, invite quieter people and different views: "What haven't we thought of?"
- **Check in privately.** If someone seems to be going along against their wishes, ask gently, away from the group.

- **Watch for exclusion.** Notice who is left out of chats, plans and jokes, and bring them in.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I noticed you went quiet when they said that. Are you okay?"
> "I'd like to hear what you think, even if it's different."

When to get more help

Group pressure is part of life. It may be time for more help if:

- a group, family or partner controls who you see, what you wear, what you spend or what you believe, or punishes you for disagreeing;
- you feel you can't leave a group without being threatened, shamed or cut off from everyone you know;
- you're being bullied, at school, at work or online;
- being left out or pressured is leaving you very low, anxious or hopeless.

Talk to someone you trust, a counsellor or a doctor. Not safe at home? lists free, private help if someone at home controls or frightens you. For low mood or worry, see Chapter 16 (page 96). If you are thinking about ending your life, please tell someone today.

In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

Reading on the website

Reading pages to read on the website

- The wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card): share how you work best, so a group can make room for you.
- Leading a group (spreadloveandacceptance.com/groups): a six-session guide with ground rules that make room for difference.
- The library on teams, including psychological safety.
- The library: family scripts, social comparison, the false consensus effect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking) and confirmation bias.
- Chapter 4 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-4-communication) on saying hard things so they land.

More for your situation

- For teens: friends and pressure
- Family rifts · In-laws
- At work
- For teachers (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-teachers)
- **More in Part Three:** Belonging and trust (page 7) · How we see each other (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-3-seeing) · Values (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-10-values)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **The pull to fit in is old and strong.** Being left out hurts, so we bend to stay in. That's human, not weak.
- ✓ **Groups shape us more than we notice:** what we say, what we think is normal, and sometimes what we're willing to do.
- ✓ **Cultures and families each have unwritten rules.** They differ a lot, and so do the people inside them.
- ✓ **You can belong and still be yourself.** One calm, kind voice saying "I see it differently" often frees others to say so too.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2 · How we see each other — Closer, Together
Bias and the stories we tell

Chapter 1 · Attachment, trust and belonging — page 7
Why belonging matters so much

Book 1 · Values, meaning and a good life — Know Yourself Kindly
Holding on to your own values

Book 3 · Two kinds of fair — Share the Load
Agreeing what fair means in your group

PUT IT TO USE



The wiring card
Share how you work best, so a group can make room for you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card



Leading a group
A six-session guide with ground rules that make room for difference
spreadloveandacceptance.com/groups



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-17-groups-in-depth

What the book adds up to

A short look back at the whole book: what each part was for, the few ideas that run through all of it, and where to go next. For anyone who has read some or all of it, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Three parts, one idea
2. Six threads that run through the book
3. Notice before you judge
4. Settle before you speak
5. Say it plainly and kindly
6. Small steps beat big pushes
7. Repair is normal
8. Your part, and only your part. Safety first
9. Where to go from here

IN SHORT:

- **Part One was about you:** where your lens came from, how you work now, and where you want to go.
- **Part Two was about sharing a life:** seeing the work, sharing it fairly, and talking about it kindly.
- **Part Three was about people:** how feelings, stress, trust, change, loss, minds and groups work.
- **The thread through all of it:** notice before you judge, settle before you speak, say it plainly and kindly, take small steps, repair, and keep everyone safe.

You don't need to have read every page to get something from this one. If you skipped around, that's how most people read. The book was written so you could start anywhere, stop anywhere and pick it up again.

Three parts, one idea

Part One: Yourself (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then) looked at the lens you see through: what life taught you, how your mind and body work now, and what matters to you next. It came first because everything else depends on it. You can't share a life well if you don't know how you work.

Part Two: Between us (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface) looked at the quiet work of running a shared life, a home, a family, a team, and how to see it, share it fairly and talk about it without blame. Each chapter came with a worksheet, because ideas only help when they turn into something you do.

Part Three: Understanding people (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings) looked at how people work: feelings, stress, how we see each other, how we talk, why we need each other, how we change, our worth, loss, different minds, values, healing, helping, anger, personality, love, worry and low mood, and the pull of groups.

Underneath all three is one idea: **most of what goes wrong between people is understandable, and much of it can be put right.** Not by trying harder to be perfect, but by seeing more clearly and acting a little more kindly.

Six threads that run through the book

The book rests on five big ideas, set out at the front: *see the whole load*, *fix the setup, not the person*, *read your state first*, *tune how you send and receive* and *notice the quiet incentives*. The six threads below are the same ideas said as everyday habits, plus one rule that sits around all of them: safety first. The table after the list shows how they match.

01

Notice before you judge.

A sharp word, a forgotten job or a quiet evening usually has a reason: tiredness, a full stress tank, a different family rule, a different kind of mind. Asking "What might be going on?" before "What's wrong with them?" changes most conversations. See Chapter 3 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-3-seeing).

02

Settle before you speak.

When the body is flooded, nobody listens well. Slow the breath, step away with a time to come back, then talk. See Chapter 2 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress) and Chapter 13 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger).

03

Say it plainly and kindly.

What happened, how it felt, what you're asking for. Clear is kind, for everyone. See Chapter 4 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-4-communication).

04

Small steps beat big pushes.

One job with one owner. One walk. One message. One step on the ladder. Change that lasts is usually small and repeated. See Chapter 6 (page 23).



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: you made it to the end! High five! Pick one small thing from the book and try it this week.

TOOL **Start in 10 minutes** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes

05

Repair is normal.

Everyone gets it wrong. What keeps relationships going is coming back: a short, real apology and a plan for next time. See Chapter 11 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing).

06

Your part, and only your part. Safety first.

You can change what you do. You can't make anyone else change, and you never have to accept being frightened, controlled or hurt. If that's happening, getting safe comes before working it out. See Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

How the six threads match the five big ideas

THREAD	BIG IDEA
Notice before you judge	See the whole load; fix the setup, not the person
Settle before you speak	Read your state first
Say it plainly and kindly	Tune how you send and receive
Small steps beat big pushes	Fix the setup, not the person; notice the quiet incentives
Repair is normal	Tune how you send and receive
Your part, and only your part. Safety first.	Not one of the five: the frame around all of them

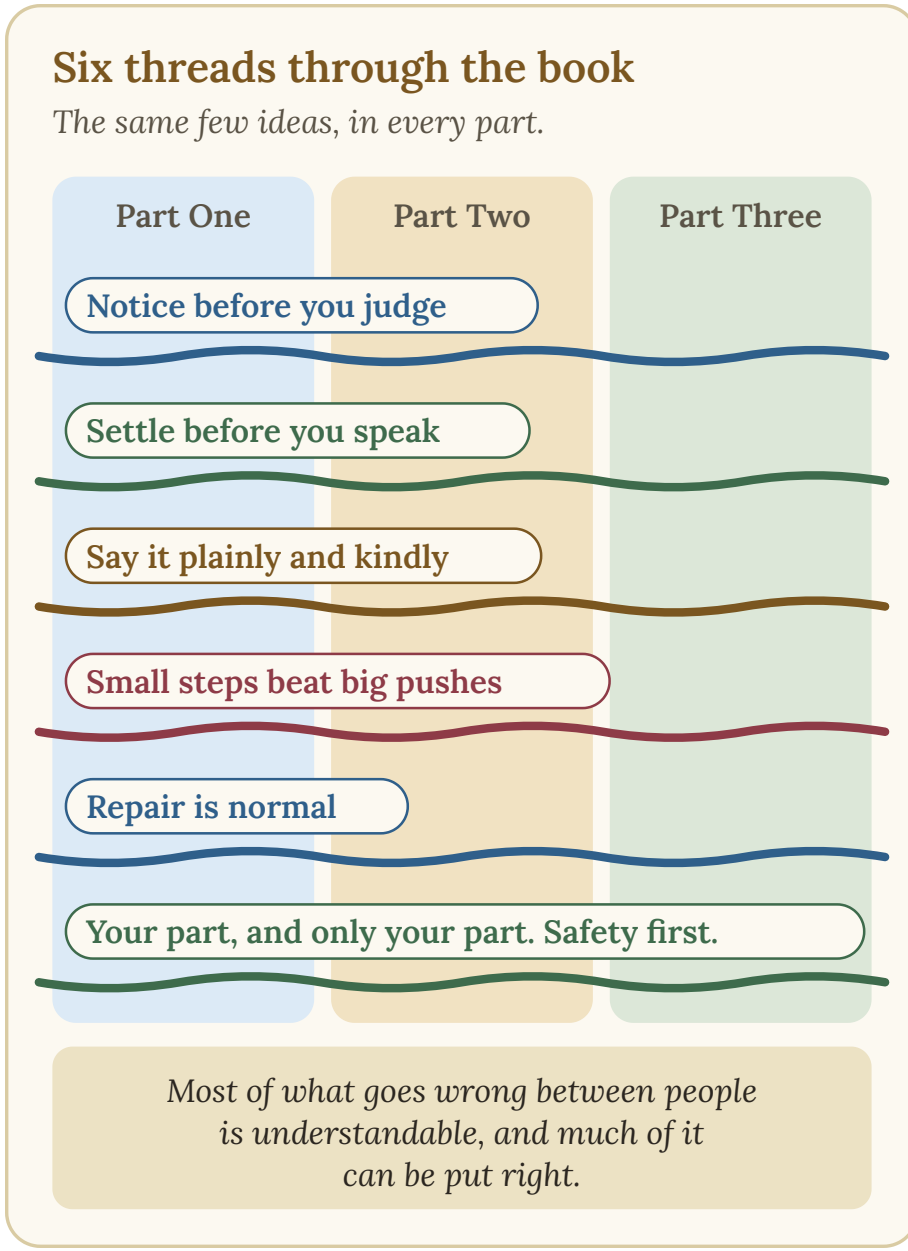


FIGURE 8 Six threads that run through the whole book, from Part One to Part Three.

Where to go from here

- **On your own:** The self path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) turns Part One into a few steps you can take at your own pace.
- **With someone:** The six-week program (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01) turns Part Two into one small step a week, for a home, a family or a team. Miss a week? Pick up anywhere.
- **With a question:** Ask Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask), the site's private helper, about anything in the book.
- **Want the evidence?** The research behind this book lists every study the book draws on, in plain words, with how strong the evidence is.
- **Read it again, differently:** every chapter has a fuller version, and the contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/) lists them all.
- **When it's more than a book can help with:** Help beyond this book (spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help) lists counsellors, helplines and support groups.

> ANY DAY, ANY TIME
>
> *You close the book. Nothing at home has changed yet. But maybe next time a sharp word lands, you'll wonder what's under it. Maybe you'll breathe out before you answer. Maybe you'll say the thing plainly, or say sorry sooner. That's all this book was ever asking for: a little more understanding, a little more often. Thank you for reading.*

This book is general education, not therapy. If you are struggling, please reach out: someone to talk to, free.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When you're ready, every workpaper in the book is in one place, to fill in on screen or to print. Start with whichever one fits this week.

WORKPAPERS **All the workpapers, to fill in on screen or print** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Part One was about you:** where your lens came from, how you work now, and where you want to go.
- ✓ **Part Two was about sharing a life:** seeing the work, sharing it fairly, and talking about it kindly.
- ✓ **Part Three was about people:** how feelings, stress, trust, change, loss, minds and groups work.
- ✓ **The thread through all of it:** notice before you judge, settle before you speak, say it plainly and kindly, take small steps, repair, and keep everyone safe.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1 · Where your lens came from
Start again at the beginning, on your own
Know Yourself Kindly

Book 3 · The work nobody sees
Start the shared part, with someone
Share the Load

Book 1 · How feelings work
Start the background chapters
Know Yourself Kindly

PUT IT TO USE



The self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



The six-week program
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/afterword-in-depth

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool the chapters point to, in two separate lists, with the chapters that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03
In: Habits and change (page **23**), Groups, influence and culture (page **101**)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09
In: Groups, influence and culture (page **101**)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11
In: Worry, low mood and trauma (page **81**)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13
In: Habits and change (page **23**)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15
In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page **7**)

WORKPAPERS **All the workpapers, to fill in on screen or print** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill
In: What the book adds up to (page **121**)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator
In: Groups, influence and culture (page **101**)

TOOL **Make a pause plan for arguments** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw
In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page 7)

TOOL **Weekly check-in card** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins
In: Groups, influence and culture (page 101)

TOOL **Turn a complaint into a request** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins
In: Worry, low mood and trauma (page 81)

TOOL **Get one small bonding idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding
In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page 7)

TOOL **How I like to be spoken to: a one-page card** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card
In: Minds that work differently (page 55), Groups, influence and culture (page 101)

TOOL **Upset right now? A 5-minute calm-down** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now
In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page 7), Habits and change (page 23), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 39), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 81)

TOOL **Calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes
In: Loss, grief and big life changes (page 39), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 81)

TOOL **How am I right now? A mood and energy check** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks
In: Habits and change (page 23), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 81)

TOOL **Talk it through in writing** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through
In: Loss, grief and big life changes (page 39)

TOOL **Ask a question in your own words** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask
In: What the book adds up to (page 121)

TOOL **Make the site fit your mind** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in
In: Minds that work differently (page 55)

TOOL **Calm football game for small kind acts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive
In: Habits and change (page 23)

TOOL **Room agreement for roommates** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room`

In: Minds that work differently (page **55**)

TOOL **10-minute team check-in** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/work`

In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page **7**), Habits and change (page **23**), Worry, low mood and trauma (page **81**), Groups, influence and culture (page **101**)

TOOL **Start in 10 minutes** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes`

In: What the book adds up to (page **121**)

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Alexithymia

Finding it hard to notice, name or describe your own feelings. It is a trait on a scale, not an illness, and it is more common in some autistic people. Naming body signals first can help.

Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, your load: a higher load score means a heavier load, and a lower battery.

A bid

A bid is any small reach for attention or connection, like "look at this," a sigh or a joke.

Calm-Down Kit

The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

Double empathy

The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

Frequency

Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

Groupthink

When a close group wants agreement so much that doubts go unsaid and a poor decision goes ahead. Irving Janis named it in 1972.

If-then plan

A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that", which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. Today's Weather calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

Masking

Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

Monotropism

A theory of autistic attention: attention gathers deeply on a few things at a time, rather than spreading thinly across many. Switching away can take real effort.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Pressure

Pressure, in Today's Weather, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Prolonged grief

Grief that stays intense and gets in the way of daily life for a long time after a death (usually a year or more for adults). It is treatable; a GP or doctor is a good first step.

Psychological safety

A shared sense in a group or team that you can speak up, ask a question or admit a mistake without being punished or embarrassed (Amy Edmondson).

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?: a load score from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 to 0.59 moderate, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Today's Weather

Today's Weather is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Window of tolerance

The range in which you can feel strong feelings and still think and talk. Above it you are flooded or revved up; below it you shut down. A phrase from the psychiatrist Dan Siegel.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A workpaper is a short worksheet. Each person fills in their own, then you read them together.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

Research notes



The 127 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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